

Internal Carbon Pricing for Scope 3 Emissions Reduction: An Institutional Readiness Assessment of Australia's Group of Eight Universities

Abstract

Universities worldwide have committed to net-zero emissions, yet the majority of their greenhouse gas footprint falls under Scope 3 — indirect emissions from travel, procurement, and supply chains that remain largely unregulated and inconsistently reported. Internal carbon pricing (ICP) is a mechanism that could help institutions manage these emissions from within, but no published study has examined whether ICP is viable for Scope 3 reduction in Australian universities. This study assesses the institutional readiness of all eight Group of Eight (Go8) universities to implement ICP through systematic document analysis of publicly available sustainability reports, greenhouse gas inventories, and climate action plans. Using an 18-variable weighted scoring rubric across four dimensions — emissions accounting maturity, governance and leadership, operational and budget autonomy, and policy and regulatory context — ICP method recommendations were generated through a two-pass allocation process. Despite overall readiness scores ranging from 20% to 72%, five universities received a proxy carbon pricing recommendation while three were recommended a carbon fee, a split driven not by overall score levels but by the operational autonomy hard barrier. No Go8 university decentralises its budget, provides departments with utility bills, or grants faculties meaningful procurement autonomy. Go8 universities have invested heavily in climate governance while the internal systems needed to act on a carbon price remain absent, a pattern consistent with institutional decoupling theory. These findings extend ICP analysis to the Australian statutory university context for the first time and show that for broad-based ICP, the path runs through finance and facilities restructuring; for targeted travel-scoped instruments, the opportunity exists now.

Keywords: *internal carbon pricing, Scope 3 emissions, higher education, institutional readiness, Group of Eight universities, sustainability governance*

Introduction

Global greenhouse gas emissions continue to rise despite thirty years of international climate agreements. The Paris Agreement aims to limit warming to 1.5°C above pre-industrial levels, but current national policies fall short of that target (Döbbeling-Hildebrandt et al., 2024). In this environment, large institutions — universities included — face growing pressure to move beyond net-zero pledges and take concrete, measurable steps to reduce their emissions.

Australia's Group of Eight (Go8) research universities have each made public net-zero commitments, joining more than one thousand universities worldwide that have done the same (Melville-Rea & Arndt, 2024). These are not small institutions. They employ tens of thousands of staff, serve hundreds of thousands of students, and operate large campuses with complex supply chains. Their emissions are correspondingly large, and the majority fall under Scope 3 — indirect emissions from sources such as business travel, staff commuting, purchased goods and services, and investments (Barron et al., 2020; Thornely, 2023).

Scope 3 is where the problem becomes difficult. Australia's National Greenhouse and Energy Reporting Act 2007 (NGER Act) requires disclosure of Scope 1 and 2 emissions above certain thresholds, but does not cover Scope 3. Reporting in this category is therefore voluntary. Universities make their own decisions about which categories to include, which methods to use, and how to present results. Thornely (2023) found that among all 41 Australian universities in 2019, these choices varied so widely that meaningful cross-institutional comparison was effectively impossible. Fan (2025) documents some improvement in Go8 Scope 3 reporting between 2020 and 2025, but finds that major inconsistencies in category coverage and methodology remain. The April 2025 publication of a joint TEFMA/ACTS Scope 3 Emissions Guideline — the first sector-level standard of its kind for Australian and New Zealand tertiary institutions — represents a direct response to this gap, though its effect on reporting consistency cannot yet be assessed (TEFMA & ACTS, 2025). Without a common reporting standard, net-zero targets that include Scope 3 cannot be verified, and emissions reductions in this category cannot be reliably tracked.

Internal carbon pricing (ICP) is one mechanism that could address this problem from within the institution. Rather than waiting for external regulation, an institution assigns a monetary value to its own emissions. This creates a financial incentive for departments to measure their carbon output, identify reductions, and account for carbon costs in purchasing and investment decisions (Gorbach et al., 2022; Harpankar, 2019). Evidence from national carbon pricing schemes — now operating in more than seventy jurisdictions — suggests that well-designed carbon pricing does reduce emissions (Döbbeling-Hildebrandt et al., 2024). At the institutional level,

Barron et al. (2020) identify three ICP instruments used by US universities, each differing in what it requires and how it works: a proxy price, a carbon fee, and a carbon fund. Importantly, these instruments do not all carry the same structural requirements. Barron et al. (2020) note that travel-targeted fees operate at the point of booking rather than through departmental billing, and therefore make fewer demands on internal budget structures than broad carbon fees do. Gorbach et al. (2022) identify two binding conditions for ICP to function: a university must be able to assign emissions to specific departments, and those departments must be able to act on a carbon price once they receive it.

Despite this body of work, several important gaps remain. First, no published study has examined whether ICP is a practical tool for Scope 3 emissions reduction in Australian universities specifically. The existing higher education ICP literature comes primarily from the United States (Barron et al., 2020; Urbaniak, 2025), where institutions operate under different governance models and funding structures. The corporate ICP literature comes from settings with different financial incentives and regulatory environments (Bento & Gianfrate, 2020; Trinks et al., 2022). Second, no study has asked whether the conditions that make ICP effective in those contexts actually exist at Go8 universities. These institutions are governed under state and territory legislation, operate within a reporting framework that excludes Scope 3, and face a voluntary policy environment where ICP is not yet externally required. Third, the Scope 3 reduction literature and the ICP implementation literature have developed largely independently. No study has brought them together to ask whether ICP is a viable mechanism for Scope 3 reduction specifically.

This study addresses those gaps through a systematic document analysis of publicly available sustainability reports, greenhouse gas inventories, and climate action plans for all eight Go8 universities. Drawing on the ICP implementation literature, an 18-variable scoring rubric was developed to assess four dimensions of institutional readiness: emissions accounting maturity, governance and leadership, operational and budget autonomy, and policy and regulatory context. ICP method recommendations are then produced through a two-pass allocation process grounded in Gorbach et al.'s (2022) implementation framework. The study makes three contributions. First, it extends ICP analysis to the Australian statutory university context, where governance and regulatory conditions have not previously been examined. Second, it produces a replicable readiness assessment instrument that can be applied to other higher education systems facing the same gap between Scope 3 commitment and Scope 3 accountability. Third, it identifies the conditions under which targeted ICP instruments — particularly travel-scoped carbon fees — are viable at institutions that cannot yet support broad carbon fees, offering a more granular implementation pathway than the existing literature provides.

Methodology

Research Design

This study uses qualitative policy analysis to assess whether Australia's Group of Eight (Go8) universities have the institutional conditions needed to implement internal carbon pricing (ICP) as a Scope 3 emissions reduction tool. Because detailed longitudinal emissions data does not currently exist at the level needed to measure ICP outcomes in Australian higher education, the study takes a conditional approach: based on what the ICP literature identifies as necessary conditions for effectiveness, how well do Go8 universities meet those conditions, and which ICP methods are most appropriate for each institution?

Three reasons justify this design. First, no peer-reviewed study has examined ICP effectiveness specifically in relation to Scope 3 emissions in universities, so drawing causal conclusions would be premature. Second, Go8 universities are statutory bodies with governance and regulatory structures that differ significantly from the corporate settings where most ICP research has been conducted. Third, assessing how well institutions meet theoretically derived conditions is a recognised contribution in the sustainability governance literature, particularly where the gap between institutional commitment and institutional capacity is itself what the study is trying to understand (Hahn & Kühnen, 2013).

Theoretical Framework

The analytical framework was developed deductively from the ICP implementation literature before data collection, following theory-driven content analysis (Bowen, 2009). Four dimensions of institutional readiness were identified through a review of peer-reviewed and grey literature sources.

Emissions accounting maturity captures how well an institution can measure and assign its greenhouse gas emissions to responsible departments, drawing on Gorbach et al.'s (2022) first implementation barrier and Barron et al.'s (2020) technical prerequisites for carbon fee schemes. Governance and leadership captures institutional authority and commitment at leadership level, drawing on Gorbach et al.'s (2022) prerequisite of top-management support, Bento and Gianfrate's (2020) finding on board-level governance quality, and Urbaniak's (2025) concept of "climate action culture." Operational and budget autonomy captures whether departments can respond to a carbon price signal, drawing on Gorbach et al.'s (2022) second implementation barrier, Barron et al.'s (2020) renter problem — where departments without utility bills have no financial relationship with energy use — and Urbaniak's (2025) demonstration that Responsibility Centre Management budget structures can deliver carbon fees by allocating indirect costs such as utilities directly to sub-units.

Barron et al. (2020) note that the renter problem applies specifically to utility-based fees; travel-targeted fees operate at the point of approval and represent a structurally distinct pathway. Policy and regulatory context captures external drivers of ICP adoption, drawing on Bento and Gianfrate (2020), Trinks et al. (2022), Harpankar (2019), and Lee and Lee (2021). Table 1 presents the full variable set, scoring criteria, weights, and literature source.

Table 1: Full Variable Set

VARIABLE		SCORING GUIDE (select score below)	Max	Weight
EMISSIONS ACCOUNTING (EA)				
EA1	Scope 1 & 2 inventory disclosed	0=Not disclosed 1=Partial 2=Fully disclosed Source: Gorbach et al. (2022)	2	1
EA2	Scope 3 categories measured (0–15)	0=None 1=1–3 cats 2=4–7 cats 3=8+ categories Source: Barron et al. (2020)	3	2
EA3	Scope 3 measurement methodology	0=None 1=Spend-based only 2=Activity/hybrid method Source: Barron et al. (2020)	2	1.5
EA4	Cost-centre emissions allocation	0=Whole-institution only 1=Some units 2=Systematic Source: Gorbach et al. (2022)	2	2
EA5	Building/dept-level energy metering	0=No sub-metering 1=Partial 2=Comprehensive Source: Barron et al. (2020)	2	1.5
Maximum Weighted Score (Score × Weight)			18	
GOVERNANCE & LEADERSHIP (GOV)				
G1	Net-zero target includes Scope 3	0=No target 1=Scope 1/2 only 2=Incl. Scope 3 Source: Gorbach et al. (2022)	2	1.5
G2	Sustainability governance at leadership	0=None 1=Advisory only 2=Formal w/ accountability Source: Bento & Gianfrate (2020)	2	2
G3	VC/DVC public ICP or climate commitment	0=None 1=General climate only 2=Explicit ICP/carbon finance Source: Gorbach et al. (2022)	2	1.5

G4	Prior ICP-adjacent mechanisms	0=None 1=One mechanism 2=Multiple mechanisms Source: Harpankar (2019); Urbaniak (2025)	2	1
G5	AASHE STARS rating	0=Not rated/Bronze 1=Silver 2=Gold 3=Platinum Source: Hahn & Kühnen (2013); Urbaniak (2025)	3	1
Maximum Weighted Score (Score × Weight)			15	
OPERATIONAL AUTONOMY (OPS)				
O1	Budget decentralisation model	0=Fully centralised 1=Partial devolution 2=RCM/IBB model Source: Urbaniak (2025)	2	2
O2	Departments billed for utilities	0=No – central billing 1=Some units 2=Systematic billing Source: Barron et al. (2020)	2	2
O3	Faculty procurement autonomy	0=Centralised 1=Partial autonomy 2=Decentralised Source: Gorbach et al. (2022)	2	1.5
O4	Active carbon-conscious travel policy	0=No policy 1=Policy not enforced 2=Active w/ tracking Source: Barron et al. (2020)	2	1
Maximum Weighted Score (Score × Weight)			13	
POLICY & REGULATORY CONTEXT (POL)				
P1	NGER/Safeguard Mechanism exposure	0=Below thresholds 1=Approaching 2=Subject to NGER Source: Bento & Gianfrate (2020)	2	1.5
P2	AASB S2/TCFD/TEFMA voluntary adoption	0=Not applicable/none 1=Voluntary 2=Formally	2	1

		committed Source: Trinks et al. (2022)		
P3	Carbon risk hedge in strategy docs	0=None 1=General risk language 2=Explicit carbon hedging Source: Harpankar (2019)	2	1
P4	Peer/normative pressure (rankings)	0=Not engaged 1=Participates 2=High performer Source: Trinks et al. (2022)	2	1
Maximum Weighted Score (Score × Weight)			9	

Abbreviations: RCM = Responsibility Centre Management; IBB = Incentive-Based Budgeting; NGER = National Greenhouse and Energy Reporting Act 2007; AASB S2 = Australian Accounting Standards Board Sustainability Standard 2; TCFD = Task Force on Climate-related Financial Disclosures; TEFMA = Tertiary Education Facilities Management Association; AASHE STARS = Association for the Advancement of Sustainability in Higher Education Sustainability Tracking, Assessment and Rating System; VC/DVC = Vice-Chancellor/Deputy Vice-Chancellor.

Two variables — prior ICP-adjacent mechanisms and AASHE STARS rating — extend rather than directly operationalise the existing literature. Harpankar (2019) provides the theoretical basis for the former, arguing that prior exposure to carbon-adjacent financial mechanisms produces organisational learning that lowers implementation barriers for more formal ICP instruments. STARS ratings are included as a proxy for sustained sustainability governance capacity, drawing on Hahn and Kühnen's (2013) finding that third-party sustainability reporting frameworks are associated with stronger internal management systems. Urbaniak (2025) provides supporting empirical context for both variables but did not theorise them as readiness predictors; their inclusion here represents an extension of his framework to a readiness assessment context.

Data Collection and Scoring Instrument

Primary data were collected through systematic document analysis of publicly available sustainability reports, climate action plans, greenhouse gas inventories, annual reports, and institutional policies for all eight Go8 universities. Documents from the 2024 reporting cycle were used for all institutions to ensure consistency. Document analysis was chosen because the variables of interest are reflected in

institutional disclosures, the method is replicable, and it avoids the self-report bias of surveys or interviews (Bowen, 2009).

An 18-variable weighted scoring rubric (Table 1) was developed to operationalise the four dimensions, producing a maximum total weighted score of 55 points. Variables grounded in the literature as prerequisite conditions received higher weights (1.5–2.0); supporting variables received lower weights (1.0). Most variables were scored on a three-point ordinal scale (0–2); two variables — EA2 and G5 — used a four-point scale (0–3). Dimension scores were normalised to a percentage of each dimension's maximum to allow cross-dimensional comparison. Full variable-level scores and source document references for all eight universities are provided in Appendix A.

ICP Method Allocation and Robustness Check

ICP recommendations were produced through a two-pass process. In the first pass, two hard barriers derived from Gorbach et al. (2022) were applied: universities scoring below 40% on emissions accounting maturity or operational autonomy were assigned proxy carbon pricing regardless of overall score. The threshold reflects Gorbach et al.'s (2022) argument that below minimum levels of emissions attribution and operational autonomy, more sophisticated instruments stop working structurally. In the second pass, universities clearing both barriers were assigned an instrument based on overall score: proxy carbon price (0–38%), organisational carbon fund (39–58%), carbon fee or flat contribution (59–75%), and hybrid system (76–100%). The three instruments differ substantially in what they require and what signal they send; Table 2 summarises their mechanics, real-world precedents, and structural prerequisites.

Table 2: ICP Instrument Types and Structural Requirements

	Proxy Carbon Price	Carbon Fee	Carbon Fund
How it works	A virtual price applied at the point of evaluating a capital project or procurement decision — the carbon cost is included as though real, but no money	An actual internal levy on departmental emissions; funds are returned to departments as rebates or directed toward abatement projects (Barron et al., 2020)	A budget reserve equal to institutional emissions multiplied by a set price, directed toward sustainability projects without passing a price signal to individual units (Barron et al., 2020)

	changes hands (Barron et al., 2020)		
Real-world example	Princeton University (capital construction, since 2008); Smith College (since 2018)	Yale University (since 2016): each administrative unit billed against a measured baseline, with funds returned in proportion to performance	Swarthmore College (since 2016): mandatory and voluntary departmental contributions accumulated ~USD 1.3 million for emissions reduction projects
What it requires	Emissions inventory and carbon cost methodology; no departmental billing infrastructure	Unit-level energy metering and a budget structure through which departments can receive and respond to a charge; achievable through Responsibility Centre Management (RCM) budgeting (Urbaniak, 2025)	Institutional-level emissions total and a centralised sustainability budget; no departmental billing infrastructure required
Price signal to departments?	No — signal operates at project evaluation only	Yes — departments receive and respond to a direct charge	No — signal operates at institutional level only

Which instrument is appropriate depends on a university's internal structure — in particular, whether departments receive their own utility bills and have meaningful authority over their spending and operations. The "price signal to departments" row maps directly onto the hard barrier logic: the carbon fee is the only instrument that requires departments to receive and respond to a charge, which is precisely why the operational autonomy barrier applies to it and not to the other two.

To test sensitivity to variable specification and weighting, a simplified four-variable framework was applied in parallel, retaining one variable per dimension with equal weighting and a maximum of nine points. Where both frameworks produce the

same recommendation, findings are reported with confidence; where they diverge, the source of divergence is noted as an analytical finding.

It is important to be precise about what the instrument's outputs represent. The two-pass allocation process produces a recommendation about instrument appropriateness — which ICP method is structurally compatible with a given university's current conditions — not a prediction of adoption likelihood or emissions outcomes. Whether recommended institutions will adopt ICP, and whether adoption will reduce Scope 3 emissions, are separate empirical questions this study does not address. This scope is deliberate. Urbaniak (2025), in a regression analysis of 170 US institutions, finds that ICP policies are not statistically associated with emissions reductions when controlling for institutional size and climatic characteristics. Attempting to measure ICP impact before the structural conditions for effectiveness are understood produces uninterpretable results. A readiness assessment is therefore the appropriate prior step — establishing the observable baseline against which adoption decisions and, eventually, emissions outcomes can be evaluated.

Results

Results are reported by dimension below, preceded by a high-level overview of overall scores and ICP method recommendations.

High-Level Findings

Table 3 presents the weighted scores and ICP method recommendations for all eight universities. Overall scores ranged from 11.0 out of 55 (Adelaide University, 20%) to 39.5 out of 55 (University of Melbourne, 72%), with a mean of 30.6 points (56%). Despite this variation, five of the eight universities received the same ICP method recommendation: proxy carbon pricing. This outcome was not determined by overall score bands. Instead, it was driven by the hard-barrier conditions derived from Gorbach et al. (2022). The University of Sydney, University of Queensland, University of Western Australia, Monash University, and Adelaide University all scored below 40% on the Operational and Budget Autonomy dimension — the second hard barrier — which means that more sophisticated ICP instruments are not workable for these universities regardless of how well they performed on other dimensions. The Australian National University, University of Melbourne, and UNSW Sydney cleared both hard barriers and are recommended for a Carbon Fee model. Across all dimensions, the robustness check produced consistent recommendations, with divergences occurring only for universities with strong governance and accounting profiles; in every case the source of divergence was the absence of departmental utility billing and budget decentralisation.

Table 3: Go8 ICP Readiness Scores and ICP Method Recommendations

University	EA	GOV	OPS	POL	Total	ICP
UniMelb	14.0 (78%)	12.0 (80%)	5.5 (42%)	8.0 (89%)	39.5 (72%)	Carbon Fee
UNSW	14.5 (81%)	9.5 (63%)	5.5 (42%)	8.0 (89%)	37.5 (68%)	Carbon Fee
ANU	12.5 (69%)	9.5 (63%)	5.5 (42%)	7.0 (78%)	34.5 (63%)	Carbon Fee
Monash	14.0 (78%)	9.0 (60%)	4.0 (31%)	7.0 (78%)	34.0 (62%)	Proxy
USyd	12.5 (69%)	8.0 (53%)	4.5 (35%)	9.0 (100%)	34.0 (62%)	Proxy
UWA	7.0 (39%)	10.5 (70%)	3.0 (23%)	8.0 (89%)	28.5 (52%)	Proxy
UQ	8.5 (47%)	8.0 (53%)	4.0 (31%)	5.0 (56%)	25.5 (46%)	Proxy
Adelaide	0 (0%)	6.5 (43%)	0 (0%)	4.5 (50%)	11.0 (20%)	Proxy

Note: EA = Emissions Accounting Maturity; GOV = Governance and Leadership; OPS = Operational and Budget Autonomy; POL = Policy and Regulatory Context. Bold percentages indicate barrier conditions (EA < 40% or OPS < 40%)

Governance and Policy scores were consistently higher than Emissions Accounting and Operational Autonomy scores across the dataset. This pattern reflects a broader trend where universities have made strong climate commitments that have not yet been matched by the technical and structural systems needed to implement an internal carbon price. The University of Melbourne achieved the highest overall score (72%), followed by UNSW Sydney (68%) and ANU (63%). The University of Queensland recorded the lowest score among fully operational universities (46%), driven by the weakest Policy dimension score in the dataset (56%) and an expired AASHE STARS rating.

While some universities achieved similar overall totals, the reasons behind those scores differ considerably. The University of Sydney and Monash University both scored 62%, but through very different profiles: the University of Sydney's result is driven by a perfect Policy dimension score (100%) and third-party-assured Scope 3 accounting, while Monash's is anchored in its emissions accounting maturity and its Flight Emissions Offset Program — the only active financial carbon mechanism among the five proxy-recommended universities. Both universities fail the

Operational Autonomy hard barrier (USyd: 35%; Monash: 31%), and both are therefore assigned a Proxy Carbon Price recommendation. Their equivalent overall totals mask these structurally identical constraints.

Methodological Note: Adelaide University

Adelaide University was established by legislation on 8 March 2024 and did not begin full operations until 1 January 2026. Its 2024 Annual Report covers only its transitional setup period, and all sustainability policies carry effective dates of 2026. Adelaide University has no reportable emissions, no obligation under the NGER Act, and no operational campus from which scores could be drawn. The methodology's conservative scoring instruction — that variables be scored 0 where evidence is absent — applies fully here, producing zeros across both the Emissions Accounting and Operational Autonomy dimensions and triggering both hard barriers. The total score of 11.0 points (20%) and the Proxy Carbon Price recommendation therefore reflect the absence of public disclosures, not a lack of institutional capacity. Adelaide University's founding Sustainability Policy already commits to a Scope 3-inclusive net-zero target by 2050 and includes explicit climate risk governance language, giving it a stronger policy foundation than several currently operational Go8 peers.

Emissions Accounting Maturity

Emissions accounting scores ranged from 0 (Adelaide University) to 14.5 out of 18 (UNSW Sydney, 81%). Among operationally active universities, the University of Melbourne and Monash University both disclosed eight or more Scope 3 categories at the highest levels — Monash reporting nine categories explicitly assessed for materiality against the GHG Protocol Corporate Value Chain Standard, and the University of Melbourne disclosing all 18 internally tracked categories in its Data Tables. The University of Sydney reported all 15 GHG Protocol categories with third-party limited assurance from BDO, the strongest methodological standard in the dataset. UNSW Sydney also reported eight or more categories, meeting the threshold for the maximum EA2 score after excluding downstream categories deemed immaterial.

Two variables scored low across all universities: cost-centre emissions allocation (EA4) and building-level energy metering (EA5). UNSW Sydney is the sole exception on EA4, scoring 1 out of 2 on the basis of its faculty- and division-level carbon dashboards in Microsoft Power BI, which assign emissions by organisational unit without any financial charge attached. No other university systematically attributed greenhouse gas emissions to internal departments for management purposes. On metering, UQ and Monash each scored 2 through sub-metering commitments and facility-level NGER reporting respectively.

UWA is an exception to the generally stronger accounting performance seen at other operationally active universities. Its Scope 3 inventory is disclosed only as a single total figure (34.3K tCO₂-e in 2024) with no category breakdown publicly available. This produced an EA2 score of 1 and an EA total of 7.0 out of 18 (39%) — placing UWA exactly at the first hard-barrier threshold. UWA's Barrier 1 result is therefore a cautious coding decision that may understate its actual internal measurement capacity.

Governance and Leadership

Governance scores ranged from 6.5 out of 15 (Adelaide University, 43%) to 12.0 out of 15 (University of Melbourne, 80%). The University of Melbourne's governance score was driven by a formal Sustainability Plan 2030 commitment — authored under the Vice-Chancellor's foreword — to conduct a feasibility study for internal carbon pricing. This is the only Go8 document to explicitly name ICP as a planned instrument and produced the sole G3 score of 2 in the dataset.

UWA achieved the second-highest governance score (10.5, 70%), driven by a current and valid AASHE STARS Silver rating (submitted December 2025) and a formal Scope 3 net-zero target by 2040. UWA is one of only three Go8 universities — alongside UNSW and the University of Melbourne — with a net-zero target that explicitly covers Scope 3.

On ICP-adjacent mechanisms (G4), three universities demonstrate structured travel carbon governance that constitutes partial operational readiness for a travel-scoped fee. Monash University's Flight Emissions Offset Program, launched in 2024, embeds offset costs directly into grant applications, provides a Carbon Smart travel guide, and is backed by an institutional Integrity Principles framework — the most advanced financial carbon mechanism in the proxy-recommended group. The University of Melbourne goes further: air travel emissions (22,092 tCO₂-e in 2024) are 100% offset using high-quality carbon credits through a partnership with Thrust Carbon, which provides ISO 14083-assured flight emissions data visible to travel bookers at the point of booking. Fleet emissions are additionally offset via Greenfleet, and the Sustainability Plan includes a target of 10% reduction in air travel emissions from 2019 levels. ANU operates a dedicated Travel Emissions Tracker tool backed by a Carbon Smart Travel Guide, has set a specific 50% reduction target for university travel emissions from 2019 levels by 2025, and conducts biennial travel surveys to monitor progress — work recognised with an Australasian Green Gown Award (Highly Commended). UNSW's faculty-level carbon dashboards scored 1 on G4 — an information system related to carbon management but without a financial pricing component attached.

The AASHE STARS variable (G5) showed the widest spread within the governance dimension. UWA is the only Go8 university with a currently valid STARS rating. The University of Sydney achieved Silver in 2021 but cancelled its 2024 re-submission due to resource constraints, scoring 1 based on the prior rating.

Operational and Budget Autonomy

Operational autonomy scores ranged from 0 (Adelaide University) to 5.5 out of 13 (ANU, University of Melbourne, and UNSW Sydney, 42%). The three universities that cleared the second hard barrier did so at exactly 42% — the minimum margin above the 40% threshold. No Go8 university demonstrates strong operational autonomy; the distinction between those that clear and those that fail the barrier is narrow and structurally driven, not a reflection of meaningfully different institutional capacity.

Departmental utility billing (O2) scored 0 for all eight universities, and budget decentralisation (O1) scored 0 for all universities except those with partial devolution, with no university exceeding a score of 1 on the latter. The Go8 operates under centralised financial governance models where sustainability budgets and utility costs are managed at the whole-institution level rather than at the department level. The renter problem described by Barron et al. (2020) — where departments without their own utility bills have no direct financial connection to their energy use and therefore cannot respond to a carbon fee — applied across the entire dataset without exception. This is consistent with the broader statutory university context in Australia, where state funding models and enterprise agreements constrain the degree to which financial accountability can be devolved to sub-units.

The only variable that produced meaningful variation in this dimension was carbon-conscious travel policy (O4). ANU, the University of Melbourne, UNSW Sydney, Monash University, and the University of Queensland each scored 2. The University of Sydney and UWA scored 1, with travel policies in place but no active tracking tools or confirmed offset mechanisms. Adelaide University scored 0, with no travel programme in operation.

Faculty procurement autonomy (O3) was the variable that most clearly separated universities clearing the OPS barrier from those that did not. ANU, the University of Melbourne, UNSW Sydney, and the University of Sydney each scored 1, reflecting structured but partially devolved delegation frameworks where units hold some spending authority within centrally defined limits. The University of Queensland, UWA, Adelaide University, and Monash University scored 0, reflecting fully centralised procurement governance in 2024.

The renter problem does not foreclose all fee-based action equally. Travel-targeted fees operate at the point of grant or trip approval and do not depend on

departmental utility billing to function. The three universities that cleared the OPS barrier did so primarily through their scores on O4 and O3, not through any resolution of the billing or budget decentralisation conditions — and all three already operate structured travel carbon mechanisms that provide an existing institutional hook for a formalised fee.

Policy and Regulatory Context

Policy and regulatory context scores ranged from 4.5 out of 9 (Adelaide University, 50%) to 9.0 out of 9 (University of Sydney, 100%). The University of Sydney is the only Go8 university to achieve a perfect Policy score. This result was driven by its designation as a Phase 1 reporting entity under NSW Treasury's mandatory AASB S2-aligned climate disclosure requirements and its voluntary publication of a standalone Climate-related Financial Disclosure for 2024, verified by BDO. The University of Melbourne, UNSW Sydney, and UWA each scored 8.0 out of 9 (89%).

NGER reporting obligation (P1) scored 2 for all operationally active universities, establishing mandatory carbon accountability as a common baseline condition across the Go8.

The voluntary climate risk disclosure variable (P2) produced the greatest variation within this dimension. The University of Sydney scored 2, having published a full voluntary disclosure ahead of mandatory requirements. The University of Melbourne, UNSW Sydney, ANU, and UWA each scored 1, reflecting preparatory work toward AASB S2 or equivalent disclosure without a formal report published in 2024. The University of Queensland scored 0 — the only fully operational Go8 university with no climate risk disclosure and no stated intention to produce one. This is consistent with its position as a Queensland statutory body outside the NSW Treasury mandatory disclosure regime and the absence of any voluntary commitment in its Sustainability Strategy.

On peer and normative pressure (P4), the University of Melbourne (9th globally, QS Sustainability Rankings), UNSW Sydney (12th globally QS, 7th THE Impact Rankings, 2nd globally SDG 13 Climate Action), the University of Sydney (11th globally QS), and UWA (current STARS Silver holder and 2024 TEFMA Innovation Award winner) each scored 2. The University of Queensland, ANU, and Monash University scored 1, reflecting active participation in sustainability networks without top-tier ranking positions.

Discussion

Recap of Major Findings

Three main findings stand out. First, the instrument produced a split result: five universities were recommended proxy carbon pricing while ANU, the University of Melbourne, and UNSW Sydney were recommended a carbon fee. This split should not be read as evidence that three universities are substantially more ready than the other five. ANU, Melbourne, and UNSW cleared the Operational and Budget Autonomy hard barrier at exactly 42% — the minimum margin above the threshold. Budget decentralisation and departmental utility billing scored zero for all eight institutions. The renter problem described by Barron et al. (2020) held across the entire dataset. That said, the renter problem does not foreclose all fee-based action equally: a fee targeting travel or procurement reaches the point of decision without requiring cost centres to be formally billed for utilities, and all three fee-recommended universities already operate structured mechanisms that provide an institutional hook for exactly this.

Second, there is a clear and consistent gap between governance commitment and operational capacity. Seven of the eight active universities scored above 50% on Governance and six above 50% on Policy, while all eight scored below 45% on Operational Autonomy. Go8 universities have invested heavily in the visible parts of climate governance while the internal systems needed to make a carbon price work remain largely absent.

Third, Scope 3 reporting has improved but there remains a significant gap between reporting breadth and internal usability. No university has systematically linked Scope 3 emissions to internal cost centres for management purposes. Reporting multiple categories is not the same as having the data systems to assign those emissions to the departments responsible for them.

Limitations

Limitation 1: The Study Can Only Assess What Universities Publish

The most significant limitation of this study is that it can only measure what universities choose to make public. Where universities track emissions internally but do not publish that data — for example, internal carbon dashboards, building-level energy figures held by facilities teams, or departmental budget processes — those systems are invisible to document analysis and are coded as absent or minimal. UWA is the clearest example: it published only a single aggregate Scope 3 figure, but it is possible that more detailed data exists internally. This produced an Emissions

Accounting score at the hard-barrier threshold — a cautious coding decision that may underestimate UWA's actual measurement capacity.

The 40% hard-barrier thresholds are treated as theoretically motivated starting points derived from Gorbach et al.'s (2022) framework, not as empirically validated cutoffs for the Australian statutory university context. To test sensitivity to this choice, the allocation logic was applied at three threshold levels — 35%, 40%, and 45% — for both the Emissions Accounting and Operational Autonomy barriers. At 35%, all recommendations remain unchanged. At 45%, ANU, the University of Melbourne, and UNSW Sydney would be reassigned from carbon fee to proxy carbon pricing, since their OPS scores of 42% fall below the raised cutoff. This divergence is reported not as a reason to distrust the 40% threshold, but as a transparent account of where the instrument's outputs are most sensitive to threshold choice. The core finding — that all eight Go8 universities score at or below 42% on operational autonomy, and that this is the binding structural constraint regardless of governance and accounting performance — holds across all three threshold levels tested.

More broadly, the study addresses this limitation through transparency: all scoring decisions are documented with reference to specific source documents, and the robustness check was designed to test how sensitive the findings are to different variable weights and specifications. It is also worth noting that Urbaniak (2025), in a regression analysis of 170 US institutions, finds that ICP policies are not statistically associated with emissions reductions when controlling for institutional size and climatic characteristics. This is consistent with the conditional framing adopted here — assessing readiness rather than impact — and reinforces that ICP's near-term value in higher education may lie primarily in governance and culture effects rather than direct emissions abatement.

Limitation 2: Sustainability Staff Were Not Contacted

This study used only publicly available documents and did not contact sustainability offices or senior operations staff at any Go8 university. This was a deliberate scope decision rather than an oversight. Document analysis produces findings that are replicable and auditable, and avoids the risk of institutions characterising their internal capacity more favourably than their published records suggest — a particular concern given the ceremonial adoption pattern the results identify. The practical constraint of coordinating responses across eight institutions within the study timeline reinforced this choice. This study therefore establishes the publicly observable structural baseline. The natural next step is qualitative research — interviews with sustainability directors and finance staff across the Go8 — that tests whether internal capacity systematically exceeds what public documents reveal.

Strengths

This study makes three contributions. First, it applies an ICP readiness framework to Australian statutory universities for the first time, extending analysis beyond the US higher education and corporate contexts where most ICP research has been conducted. Second, the 18-variable instrument is theory-based, transparent, and replicable — other researchers can apply it to different university systems or use it longitudinally within the Go8. Third, the study bridges two bodies of research that have developed largely independently: the Scope 3 reporting literature (Thornely, 2023; Fan, 2025) and the ICP implementation literature (Barron et al., 2020; Gorbach et al., 2022). It is the first study to ask whether ICP is a viable mechanism for Scope 3 reduction specifically.

Coherence with Existing Literature

The findings are broadly consistent with existing research, while also extending and qualifying it in specific ways.

The finding that operational autonomy is the key barrier to ICP at Go8 universities directly confirms Gorbach et al.'s (2022) two-barrier framework. Departmental utility billing scored zero across all eight institutions, and budget decentralisation scored zero or 1 across all seven operationally active universities — stronger evidence of this barrier than the corporate literature might lead one to expect. In corporate research, the renter problem is a challenge that some organisations face; in the Australian statutory university context, it is a universal structural condition. The three universities recommended for a carbon fee cleared the threshold not because they have genuinely decentralised budget structures, but because partial faculty procurement autonomy and active travel policies pushed their scores just above 40%. Clearing the barrier is not the same as being fully ready for fee-based ICP in practice.

Barron et al. (2020) show, however, that the renter problem does not apply equally to all ICP instruments. Travel-targeted fees function as signalling tools and do not require departmental billing infrastructure. For ANU, Melbourne, and UNSW, this is not a theoretical option: all three already operate structured mechanisms that could serve as the foundation for a formalised fee. ANU's Travel Emissions Tracker and 50% reduction target show that emissions data is already collected at the granularity a travel fee requires. Melbourne's point-of-booking flight emissions visibility provides the behavioural nudge infrastructure that a pricing overlay would directly build on. The renter problem is therefore best understood as a ceiling on the scope of fee-based ICP, not a barrier to all forms of it. Deferring fee-based action until billing structures are reformed risks means-ends decoupling in reverse: governance

commitment without the operational follow-through that gives it substance. A travel-scoped carbon fee is not a compromise — it is a starting point that begins closing the governance-capacity gap from the operational end (Harpankar, 2019).

A useful sensitivity test is to ask what the allocation results would look like if the OPS hard barrier were removed entirely and universities were assigned instruments based on overall score alone. Under that scenario, Monash University and the University of Sydney would move from proxy carbon pricing to a carbon fee recommendation, and UWA and UQ would move to a carbon fund — a meaningfully more optimistic set of findings. This possibility is not hypothetical: The University of Tasmania (UTAS) has established an internal carbon budget covering air travel, transport fuels, and paper usage under its Emissions Reduction Strategic Plan 2022–2030, with financial consequences for departments that exceed their allocations (TEFMA & ACTS, 2025). UTAS meets neither the RCM nor the departmental utility billing condition, yet it has achieved department-level emissions accountability through carbon budgets allocated by emissions category — demonstrating that the barrier as operationalised here may be misspecified.

Gorbach et al.'s (2022) underlying requirement is that departments must be able to receive and respond to a carbon price signal — not that they must do so through utility billing. The rubric captures one route to meeting that requirement but not the only one. Whether the proxy-recommended Go8 universities could implement a UTAS-style mechanism is a question this study cannot answer from public documents alone, and the document evidence gives no indication that any of the eight is currently moving in this direction — so the findings stand as reported. Future iterations of the instrument should nonetheless consider carbon budget allocation as a third qualifying mechanism alongside utility billing and RCM budgeting. The conservative framing adopted here is therefore best understood as a floor rather than a ceiling: institutions assigned a proxy price may well be closer to fee-based action than their OPS scores suggest, provided they are willing to pursue emissions budget pathways that bypass the renter problem entirely.

The governance-capacity gap fits a well-known pattern in organisational sociology. Meyer and Rowan (1977) argue that organisations facing external pressure adopt the visible structures of a practice to gain legitimacy while keeping those structures separate from day-to-day operations. Bromley and Powell (2012) distinguish between policy-practice decoupling — where a policy is adopted but not implemented — and means-ends decoupling, where policies are implemented but not connected to the goals they are meant to achieve. The Go8 pattern fits the second type: universities have genuine sustainability governance structures, but those structures are not linked to the internal accountability systems that ICP would need to function. DiMaggio and Powell's (1983) concept of mimetic isomorphism helps explain why all

eight universities show similar governance patterns despite scoring very differently overall — net-zero targets and sustainability rankings are publicly visible and rewarded, while energy metering and budget decentralisation are not.

The Policy dimension findings are consistent with the broader literature. Bento and Gianfrate (2020) and Trinks et al. (2022) find that regulatory pressure is the strongest predictor of ICP adoption in corporate settings. The University of Sydney, which faces mandatory climate disclosure requirements under NSW Treasury, scored highest on the conditions associated with ICP adoption. What the study shows, however, is that regulatory pressure raises governance readiness without automatically resolving the operational prerequisites for ICP to function — a distinction the corporate literature does not need to make but the Australian statutory context requires.

The study is in partial tension with Lee and Lee (2021), who argue that universities are well-suited to ICP experimentation because of their long-term focus and mission orientation. The Australian statutory context presents a harder version of this challenge — but the tension largely dissolves for travel-targeted instruments, where their argument holds precisely in the domain where the renter problem does not apply.

Implications for Future Research

This study raises three questions it cannot answer on its own. The most pressing is whether the operational autonomy constraints found here will change over time. Go8 universities' centralised financial governance models are not fixed permanently — they reflect decisions about regulation, management, and funding. Urbaniak (2025) shows that RCM budgeting at US universities can support carbon fees by giving departments greater financial accountability. Whether a similar approach could work in Australian statutory universities — where state funding models and industrial agreements may limit budget decentralisation — is an open question. Research tracking how Go8 universities respond to Scope 3 obligations as mandatory climate disclosure requirements are phased in would help answer it.

A related gap is whether travel-targeted carbon fees at ANU, Melbourne, and UNSW actually produce the organisational learning and emissions impact that Harpankar (2019) and Urbaniak (2025) suggest. These three universities have the governance infrastructure and offset mechanisms to implement a travel-scoped fee without structural reform. Whether doing so narrows the governance-capacity gap over time — or whether it remains a contained instrument without broader institutional effect — is an empirical question that longitudinal research could answer. Monash University's Flight Emissions Offset Program is the only active financial carbon mechanism among the proxy-recommended universities; a study of its cost per tonne of abatement and its effect on travel patterns would produce the first

empirical evidence on ICP effectiveness for Scope 3 in an Australian university setting.

Third, the readiness instrument could be applied longitudinally and comparatively — tracking whether the governance-capacity gap narrows over time within the Go8, or testing whether the operational autonomy barrier observed here holds across comparable systems such as the UK Russell Group or Canadian U15. Adelaide University offers a particular test case: whether strong foundational governance commitments accelerate the development of operational capacity over its first few reporting cycles. Whether any Go8 university adopts a UTAS-style emissions budget pathway — and whether doing so produces the departmental accountability that broader ICP would require — is the most immediate empirical question this study opens.

Implications for Practice

The findings point to a clear practical conclusion: all eight Go8 universities can act on ICP now, but the appropriate starting point differs by institution.

For the five proxy-recommended universities — Sydney, UQ, UWA, Monash, and Adelaide — the immediate opportunity is embedding a proxy price into capital project evaluation and procurement tendering. Most already hold the Scope 3 inventory coverage this requires. Sydney is the strongest candidate, given its perfect Policy score and third-party-assured Scope 3 accounting.

For ANU, the University of Melbourne, and UNSW Sydney — recommended for a carbon fee — the 42% OPS clearance is a qualified green light, not an unconditional one. The billing infrastructure constraint identified by Barron et al. (2020) applies to utility-based Scope 1 and 2 emissions — energy costs paid centrally with no financial relationship between departments and the bills they generate. Scope 3 emissions are structurally different: they are produced through decisions that departmental agents already make and control — research travel approvals, conference attendance, equipment procurement, and contracted services. As established above, Gorbach et al.'s (2022) underlying condition requires that departments can receive and respond to a carbon price signal, not that this signal be delivered through a utility bill. A broad departmental carbon fee remains structurally premature. A travel-scoped fee is available now, and evidence from comparable contexts suggests that beginning with an operational instrument produces the organisational learning that broader implementation later builds on (Harpankar, 2019; Urbaniak, 2025), though whether this pathway holds in Australian statutory universities remains an open empirical question.

Across all eight universities, broad-based ICP requires the same two conditions that scored zero across the entire dataset: departmental utility billing and budget decentralisation. These are not permanent barriers — emissions budget mechanisms can deliver equivalent departmental accountability without them, as the sensitivity analysis above shows — but no Go8 university is currently moving in this direction. The path to broad ICP runs through finance and facilities. For travel-scoped instruments, the opportunity exists now.

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Appendix A

Go8 ICP Readiness Assessment — Scoring Instrument and Evidence Record

This appendix documents the complete scoring record for the 18-variable ICP Readiness Assessment Instrument applied to all eight Group of Eight (Go8) universities. Section A.1 presents the scoring logic and variable definitions. Section A.2 presents the dimension-level scoring summary. Section A.3 provides the full evidence record, with scored values and cleaned justifications for every variable–university combination.

A.1 Scoring Logic and ICP Recommendation Thresholds

Hard Barrier 1	If Emissions Accounting dimension score < 40% of maximum, the university is assigned a Proxy Carbon Price recommendation regardless of total score. Rationale: a university cannot implement a fee-based ICP without cost-centre emissions allocation (Gorbach et al., 2022).
Hard Barrier 2	If Operational Autonomy dimension score < 40% of maximum, the university is assigned a Proxy Carbon Price recommendation regardless of total score. Rationale: cost centres cannot respond meaningfully to a price signal without operational autonomy (Gorbach et al., 2022).
Score 76–100%	Hybrid System (Carbon Fee + Proxy Price)
Score 59–75%	Carbon Fee / Flat Contribution
Score 39–58%	Organisational Carbon Fund
Score 0–38%	Proxy Carbon Price

A.2 Dimension-Level Scoring Summary

Metric	ANU	UniMelb	USyd	UQ	UWA	Adelaide	Monash	UNSW
Emissions Accounting (max 18)	12.5 (69%)	14 (78%)	12.5 (69%)	8.5 (47%)	7 (39%)	0 (0%)	14 (78%)	14.5 (81%)
Governance & Leadership (max 15)	9.5 (63%)	12 (80%)	8 (53%)	8 (53%)	10.5 (70%)	6.5 (43%)	9 (60%)	9.5 (63%)
Operational Autonomy (max 13)	5.5 (42%)	5.5 (42%)	4.5 (35%)	4 (31%)	3 (23%)	0 (0%)	4 (31%)	5.5 (42%)
Policy & Regulatory Context (max 9)	7 (78%)	8 (89%)	9 (100%)	5 (56%)	8 (89%)	4.5 (50%)	7 (78%)	8 (89%)
Total Weighted Score (max 55)	34.5 (63%)	39.5 (72%)	34 (62%)	25.5 (46%)	28.5 (52%)	11 (20%)	34 (62%)	37.5 (68%)
Barrier 1: Emissions Accounting < 40%?	✓ Clear	✓ Clear	✓ Clear	✓ Clear	⚠ BARRIER	⚠ BARRIER	✓ Clear	✓ Clear

Barrier 2: Operational Autonomy < 40%?	✓ Clear	✓ Clear	⚠ BARRIER	⚠ BARRIER	⚠ BARRIER	⚠ BARRIER	⚠ BARRIER	✓ Clear
Recommended ICP Method	Carbon Fee / Flat Contribution	Carbon Fee / Flat Contribution	Proxy Carbon Price	Proxy Carbon Price	Proxy Carbon Price	Proxy Carbon Price	Proxy Carbon Price	Carbon Fee / Flat Contribution

A.3 Full Evidence Record

Each sub-section below presents the scored values and documentary evidence for one variable across all eight Go8 universities. Scores are reproduced without alteration from the coding instrument. Justifications have been edited for clarity and consistency of prose style; the underlying evidential content is unchanged.

Dimension 1 — Emissions Accounting

EAI • Scope 1 & 2 inventory disclosed

Scoring guide: 0=Not disclosed | 1=Partial | 2=Fully disclosed | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×1

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	2 / 2	Fully itemised by source (natural gas, fleet, refrigerants, electricity) in the Carbon Accounting Methodology 2024 Appendix C and the Environmental Sustainability Report 2024. Scope 1 = 15,567 tCO ₂ -e; Scope 2 (market-based) = 29,098 tCO ₂ -e. NGER-reported figures also confirmed via the CER register.

University of Melbourne	2 / 2	Full Scope 1 and 2 inventory disclosed across all documents, broken down by source category. Scope 1 = 15,567 tCO ₂ -e; Scope 2 (market-based) = 29,098 tCO ₂ -e for 2024. Verified against the NGER CER database (Scope 1 = 14,901 tCO ₂ -e; Scope 2 = 92,066 tCO ₂ -e for 2023–24). Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 70; Data Tables, GHG emissions by scope.
University of Sydney	2 / 2	Full Scope 1 and 2 inventory disclosed in multiple documents, with location-based and market-based Scope 2 figures broken down by source, and NGER submission confirmed. Scope 1 = 6,604 tCO ₂ -e (2024 calendar year). Source: Sustainability Strategy Annual Report 2024, p. 34; Annual Report 2024, p. 56.
University of Queensland	2 / 2	Full Scope 1 and 2 inventory confirmed via the NGER CER public register (2023–24): Scope 1 = 2,319 tCO ₂ -e; Scope 2 = 103,886 tCO ₂ -e. The Sustainability Strategy also confirms NGER reporting obligation. Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, p. 17; NGER CER register screenshot.
University of Western Australia	2 / 2	Full Scope 1 and 2 inventory disclosed on the publicly accessible Sustainable Campus Dashboard, with historic data from 2022–2025 and source-level breakdown (natural gas, fleet, refrigerants). From 2025, 100% of electricity is sourced from renewable wind energy. Source: Sustainable Campus Dashboard; Sustainable Campus Operations page.
Adelaide University	0 / 2	Adelaide University had no operational emissions in 2024. No Scope 1 or 2 inventory is disclosed for the new entity. The NGER register shows no entry for Adelaide University's ABN. Foundation universities (UoA, UniSA) hold separate NGER registrations transferring to Adelaide University from 2026. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 44; NGER CER screenshot.
Monash University	2 / 2	Full Scope 1 and 2 inventory disclosed and broken down by source (natural gas, liquid fuels, refrigerants, electricity) using both location-based and market-based methods, with voluntary independent limited assurance from a registered NGER auditor. Source: ESG Report 2024, p. 39.
UNSW Sydney	2 / 2	Full Scope 1 and 2 inventory disclosed and broken down by source (natural gas, refrigerants, livestock, electricity), with independent third-party assurance from BSI Group ANZ to ISO 14064-1:2018. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 10.

EA2 • Scope 3 categories measured (0–15)

Scoring guide: 0=None | 1=1–3 categories | 2=4–7 categories | 3=8+ categories | Max score: 3 | Weight: ×2

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	3 / 3	Fully itemised Scope 3 inventory covering 18 distinct categories, including professional services, construction, air travel, ICT, food, waste, commuting, and stationary energy. Total Scope 3 = highest absolute figure in the Go8 dataset. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 5 and p. 42.
University of Melbourne	3 / 3	The Data Tables document presents a fully itemised Scope 3 inventory covering 18 distinct categories totalling 175,574 tCO ₂ -e — the largest absolute Scope 3 total in the Go8 dataset. Measurement covers the entire procurement spend. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 69; Data Tables, GHG emissions by category 2024.
University of Sydney	3 / 3	All 15 GHG Protocol Scope 3 categories are reported, with limited assurance from BDO. This is the most comprehensive category-level Scope 3 disclosure of any Go8 university in this dataset. Total = 349,578 tCO ₂ -e. Source: Climate-related Financial Disclosure 2024, pp. 22–23.
University of Queensland	1 / 3	The Sustainability Strategy commits to establishing an airline travel emissions inventory and offset framework, and the 'beyond carbon neutral' ambition references agricultural and Scope 3 emissions. However, no multi-category Scope 3 inventory is publicly disclosed in the 2024 Annual Report. Score reflects a single confirmed category (airline travel). Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, pp. 17, 19.
University of Western Australia	1 / 3	Scope 3 is disclosed as a single aggregate figure (34.3K tCO ₂ -e in 2024) on the Dashboard, with qualitative examples including waste, air travel, purchased goods, and commuting. The Annual Report notes UWA 'further developed its Scope 3 emissions reporting capabilities' in

		2024. No category-level breakdown is publicly available. Score reflects acknowledged measurement without category-level disclosure. Source: Dashboard screenshot; Annual Report 2024, p. 43.
Adelaide University	0 / 3	No Scope 3 inventory exists. The Sustainability Policy commits to net zero by 2050 incorporating full Scope 3 value chain emissions, but this is a prospective commitment rather than a current measurement. Source: Sustainability Policy, Principle 3.5 (effective 11 March 2026).
Monash University	3 / 3	Monash measures and reports nine Scope 3 categories: Cat. 1 (Purchased Goods & Services), Cat. 2 (Capital Goods), Cat. 3 (Fuel/energy), Cat. 4 (Upstream transport), Cat. 5 (Waste), Cat. 6 (Business travel), Cat. 7 (Employee commuting), Cat. 13 (Downstream leased assets), and Cat. 15 (Investments). Categories 8–12 are explicitly excluded as downstream categories not applicable to a university. Source: ESG Report 2024, p. 41 (Appendix 3).
UNSW Sydney	3 / 3	UNSW reports eight Scope 3 categories: Cat. 1 (Purchased Goods & Services), Cat. 2 (Capital Goods), Cat. 3 (Upstream energy), Cat. 5 (Waste), Cat. 6 (Business travel), Cat. 7 (Employee commuting), Cat. 13 (Tenant energy), and Cat. 15 (Investments). Categories 4, 9, 11, and 12 are excluded where under 1% of total emissions. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, pp. 10–11.

EA3 • Scope 3 measurement methodology

Scoring guide: 0=None | 1=Spend-based only | 2=Activity/hybrid method | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×1.5

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	2 / 2	ANU applies the GHG Protocol Corporate Accounting and Reporting Standard, supplemented by sector-specific guidance from the SCEF. Appendix E documents

		per-category data sources and quality ratings, confirming a hybrid approach. Source: Carbon Accounting Methodology 2024, pp. 5, 46–47.
University of Melbourne	2/2	UniMelb uses a hybrid methodology combining supplier-specific emissions data (collected directly under the Sustainable Procurement Roadmap), activity-based data (flight km via Unitravel/Thrust Carbon to ISO 14083), and spend-based data for remaining categories. A life-cycle assessment (LCA) was conducted for the Dookie student accommodation capital project in 2024. Source: Climate Leadership page; Annual Report 2024, p. 71.
University of Sydney	2/2	USyd employs a hybrid EEIO + process-based approach carried out by its own Integrated Sustainability Analysis (ISA) research group using the GLORIA multi-region input-output database — substantially beyond spend-based methods. Source: Climate-related Financial Disclosure 2024, pp. 21–22.
University of Queensland	1/2	The strategy acknowledges the need to count, report, and reduce Scope 3 emissions, and commits to establishing a Scope 3 airline travel inventory. No detailed methodology document is publicly available. Score of 1 reflects acknowledged intent without a documented hybrid methodology. Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, p. 19.
University of Western Australia	1/2	UWA references GHG Protocol alignment and is developing an Emissions Reduction Plan for 2026. The Dashboard and web pages describe Scope 3 qualitatively without specifying whether an activity-based, spend-based, or hybrid method is used. Score of 1 reflects acknowledged measurement without documented hybrid methodology. Source: Dashboard screenshot (Scope 3 Targets section).
Adelaide University	0/2	No evidence of any emissions measurement methodology. Not applicable at this stage of institutional development.
Monash University	2/2	Monash applies a hybrid LCA/spend-based approach aligned with the GHG Protocol Corporate Value Chain Standard and the NGER framework. Third-party data is used for investment emissions (Cat. 15). Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 103 (Carbon management section).

UNSW Sydney	2 / 2	UNSW applies a hybrid LCA/activity-based approach incorporating spend data, consumption data, and LCA databases aligned with the GHG Protocol Corporate Value Chain Standard. This approach is described as providing 'a complete picture of its material emissions sources' in alignment with global best practice and proposed AASB requirements. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 10.
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EA4 • Cost-centre emissions allocation

Scoring guide: 0=Whole-institution only | 1=Some units | 2=Systematic | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×2

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	0 / 2	No evidence of systematic emissions allocation to cost centres. The inventory is institution-wide. Sub-metering exists for some buildings but is explicitly noted as incomplete. Source: Carbon Accounting Methodology 2024, p. 15.
University of Melbourne	0 / 2	No evidence of emissions being allocated to cost centres, faculties, or schools. The inventory is institution-wide. The Smart Campus Energy program tracks building-level performance but is not used as an internal cost-centre charging mechanism. Source: All four documents reviewed; no counter-evidence found.
University of Sydney	0 / 2	No evidence of emissions being allocated to cost centres, colleges, or faculties. The AUMS rollout addresses data gaps rather than establishing internal attribution. Source: Sustainability Strategy Annual Report 2024, p. 33.
University of Queensland	0 / 2	No evidence of emissions being allocated to cost centres, faculties, or schools. Sustainability governance is coordinated through the Sustainability Strategy Committee at institution-wide level. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 27.

University of Western Australia	0 / 2	No evidence of emissions being allocated to cost centres, schools, or faculties. The Office of Sustainability sits within the CFO portfolio and reports institution-wide. The Dashboard is a public transparency tool, not an internal management instrument. Source: Governance and Reporting page.
Adelaide University	0 / 2	No evidence of any internal emissions attribution mechanism. Not applicable at this stage of institutional development.
Monash University	0 / 2	No evidence of systematic emissions allocation to cost centres or faculties. The inventory is institution-wide. A Master of Business Analytics internship project analysed Scope 3 data for benchmarking purposes, but this is research analytics rather than operational cost-centre allocation. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 83.
UNSW Sydney	1 / 2	UNSW has developed interactive Microsoft Power BI carbon dashboards breaking down emissions by faculty and division, enabling cross-unit comparison and explicitly aimed at driving behavioural change. This represents meaningful attribution capability without financial charging. Score of 1 reflects partial capability — attribution without internal pricing. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 10.

EA5 • Building/dept-level energy metering

Scoring guide: 0=No sub-metering | 1=Partial | 2=Comprehensive | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×1.5

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	1 / 2	Sub-metering exists and is being expanded but coverage is incomplete and explicitly flagged as a data improvement area. The Acton campus uses a micro-grid with many, but not all, buildings sub-metered. Source: Carbon Accounting Methodology 2024, p. 15.
University of Melbourne	2 / 2	The Smart Campus Energy Upgrades Program (six years in, \$45.6m committed) delivers building-level energy performance tracking with verified savings by building (e.g. Baillieu

		Library HVAC upgrades = 2.7 GWh p.a.). Statistical models forecast energy use at both building and campus levels. Source: Climate Leadership page.
University of Sydney	1 / 2	Sub-metering is being actively expanded via AUMS (28 buildings installed in 2024) but is explicitly described as addressing an existing data gap — confirming current coverage is incomplete. Source: Sustainability Strategy Annual Report 2024, p. 33.
University of Queensland	2 / 2	UQ identifies sub-metering and energy auditing as key operational tools, with energy audits completed in 2024. Sub-metering is named alongside demand management as a core energy reduction mechanism. Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, p. 15; Annual Report 2024, p. 27.
University of Western Australia	1 / 2	The Sustainable Campus Dashboard tracks energy consumption at campus level and received a TEFMA AECOM Innovation Award for its transparency capabilities. No evidence of sub-building or departmental metering in publicly available documents. Source: Governance and Reporting page; Annual Report 2024, p. 42.
Adelaide University	0 / 2	No campus operational data disclosed. Adelaide University has no owned or operated campus infrastructure in 2024, with campuses transferring from foundation universities in 2026.
Monash University	2 / 2	Energy consumption is reported by individual campus facility across 11 distinct sites (Caulfield, Clayton, Parkville, Peninsula, Gippsland, Alfred Hospital, Monash Medical Centre, Monash College, City Sites, Rural Health, Foundation) under NGER. This is the most granular campus-level energy disclosure in the Go8 dataset. Source: Annual Report 2024, pp. 104–105.
UNSW Sydney	1 / 2	Energy data is reported at campus level (Kensington, Paddington, Randwick). No evidence of sub-building metering beyond campus-aggregate reporting in publicly available documents. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 26.

Dimension 2 — Governance & Leadership

G1 • Net-zero target includes Scope 3

Scoring guide: 0=No target | 1=Scope 1/2 only | 2=Including Scope 3 | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×1.5

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	2 / 2	The net-zero target explicitly covers Scope 3 value chain emissions with a 2040 deadline. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 13.
University of Melbourne	2 / 2	Carbon targets explicitly cover all Scope 3 categories as part of the Climate Active carbon neutral by 2025 commitment and the climate positive by 2030 target. Source: Sustainability Plan 2030, pp. 18–20.
University of Sydney	1 / 2	The formal net-zero target is explicitly limited to Scope 1 and 2 by 2030. Scope 3 is measured and acknowledged as material but no formal Scope 3 target has been set; this is deferred to the post-2025 strategy. Source: Climate-related Financial Disclosure 2024, pp. 17, 23.
University of Queensland	1 / 2	UQ's 'beyond carbon neutral' vision references agricultural and Scope 3 emissions, but this is articulated as an aspiration rather than a time-bound commitment. The Annual Report lists it as a KPI without a target year. Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, p. 19; Annual Report 2024, p. 26.
University of Western Australia	2 / 2	A formal net-zero Scope 3 target by 2040 is explicitly stated on the Sustainable Campus Dashboard. An Emissions Reduction Plan is planned for 2026 to operationalise this target. Source: Dashboard screenshot (Scope 3 Targets and Initiatives section).
Adelaide University	2 / 2	The founding Sustainability Policy commits to net zero by 2050 incorporating the full Scope 3 value chain. This is a Council-level policy document rather than a strategy aspiration. The 2050 horizon is the weakest in the Go8 dataset. Source: Sustainability Policy, Principle 3.5 (effective 11 March 2026).

Monash University	1 / 2	Monash's formal net-zero commitment covers Australian campus Scope 1 and 2 emissions by 2030. Scope 3 flight emissions are offset separately but no reduction target has been set for other Scope 3 categories. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 102; ESG Report 2024, p. 41.
UNSW Sydney	2 / 2	UNSW's science-based target explicitly covers total Scope 1, 2, and 3 emissions with staged milestones (30% by 2025 — achieved; 50% by 2030; net zero by 2050). This is developed using the SBTi methodology. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, pp. 10–11.

G2 • Sustainability governance at leadership level

Scoring guide: 0=None | 1=Advisory only | 2=Formal with accountability | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×2

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	2 / 2	The Environmental Sustainability portfolio sits within ANU Campus Environment with formal management structures. An Environmental Management Plan with pillar-level accountability is published, and emissions reduction KPIs are embedded in the 2025 Corporate Plan. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 11.
University of Melbourne	2 / 2	The COO Portfolio holds overall accountability for sustainability strategy and governance. A Sustainability Advisory Group comprising executives, academic staff, and students guides implementation, with the COO reporting regularly to University Executive. Council oversight operates through the Audit and Risk Committee and Finance Committee. Source: Sustainability Plan 2030, pp. 58–59.
University of Sydney	2 / 2	A multi-tiered governance structure exists with named roles, Senate oversight through Finance and Audit Committee, Performance and Risk Committee, University Executive, and a Sustainability Program Control Board (PCB) chaired by the Vice-Provost. The PCB met six times in 2024. Climate risks are embedded in the Enterprise Risk Register. Source:

		Climate-related Financial Disclosure 2024, p. 5; Sustainability Strategy Annual Report 2024, pp. 68–69.
University of Queensland	2 / 2	A university-wide Sustainability Strategy Committee was established in 2024, chaired at senior level. Senate oversight operates through the Risk and Audit Committee and Campus Infrastructure Committee. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 27; Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, pp. 27–28.
University of Western Australia	2 / 2	The Office of Sustainability sits within the CFO portfolio, with the CFO as Executive Sponsor — direct C-suite accountability. Senate oversight via the Strategic Resources Committee covers campus planning. STARS Silver documentation confirms systematic governance. Source: Governance and Reporting page; Annual Report 2024, p. 43.
Adelaide University	1 / 2	The Sustainability Policy establishes Council-level accountability with the DVC Corporate as policy owner. Transition Council established Audit and Risk Committee (August 2024) and Finance Committee (December 2024), both of which will oversee sustainability governance from 2026. No dedicated sustainability committee operated in 2024. Score of 1 reflects a formal commitment without yet-operative governance. Source: Sustainability Policy, Principle 3.9.
Monash University	2 / 2	Monash has a dedicated ESG & Estates Committee as a standing committee of Council, chaired by the Deputy Chancellor, with the Chancellor and VC as ex-officio members. The Committee met six times in 2024. Each of the nine ESG priority areas has a named Senior Executive lead. Source: ESG Report 2024, pp. 16–17.
UNSW Sydney	2 / 2	Council formally considered environmental sustainability reports in 2024. The Sustainable Procurement Framework was endorsed by the University Leadership Team. Council's Safety and Risk Committee reviews top enterprise risks biannually, and climate risk assessments were conducted in 2024. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 18; Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 23.

G3 • VC/DVC public ICP or climate commitment

Scoring guide: 0=None | 1=General climate only | 2=Explicit ICP/carbon finance | Max score: 2

Weight: ×1.5

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	1/2	The Vice-Chancellor's foreword addresses climate and sustainability but does not mention ICP or carbon finance mechanisms. Score of 1 reflects general climate leadership without explicit ICP commitment. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 4.
University of Melbourne	2/2	The Sustainability Plan 2030, under the VC's foreword, explicitly commits to conducting a feasibility study for an internal carbon price. This is the only Go8 document with explicit ICP language from university leadership. Source: Sustainability Plan 2030, p. 20.
University of Sydney	1/2	The Chancellor and Vice-Chancellor jointly signed the forewords to both the Sustainability Report and Climate-related Financial Disclosure, explicitly committing to climate action. No mention of ICP, shadow pricing, or carbon finance mechanisms. Source: Climate-related Financial Disclosure 2024, p. 2.
University of Queensland	1/2	The VC foreword to the Sustainability Strategy articulates a 'beyond carbon neutral' vision and global sustainability leadership aspiration. The 2024 Annual Report VC review does not specifically address climate. No explicit ICP language found. Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, p. 5.
University of Western Australia	1/2	The VC's foreword and UWA 2030 strategy document do not address ICP, shadow pricing, or carbon finance instruments. Climate sustainability is embedded in the UWA 2030 strategy as a campus priority, without carbon pricing language. Source: UWA 2030 Full Report, p. 25.
Adelaide University	1/2	The co-VCs' foreword in the Annual Report does not address sustainability or climate. The Sustainability Policy (VC-approved) contains a net-zero commitment and climate risk language, but no mention of ICP or carbon pricing instruments. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 5; Sustainability Policy.

Monash University	1 / 2	The VC's foreword addresses Monash's carbon progress directly, noting a 62% reduction from the 2015 baseline. No mention of ICP, shadow pricing, or carbon finance instruments. Source: ESG Report 2024, p. 5.
UNSW Sydney	1 / 2	The VC's foreword explicitly links climate change to the University's core mission and names environmental sustainability as a strategic pillar in the new 10-year strategy. No mention of ICP, shadow pricing, or carbon finance. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, pp. 3–4.

G4 • Prior ICP-adjacent mechanisms

Scoring guide: 0=None | 1=One mechanism | 2=Multiple mechanisms | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×1

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	1 / 2	The Environmental Sustainability Plan 2026–2030 formally institutionalises the Carbon Smart Travel Program — a centralised travel system incorporating carbon-conscious decision-making — and mandates annual emissions reporting from suppliers under contracts. These constitute nascent ICP-adjacent mechanisms. Source: ESP 2026–2030, pp. 20, 33.
University of Melbourne	2 / 2	Two confirmed ICP-adjacent mechanisms: (1) air travel emissions are 100% offset via high-quality carbon credits; (2) fleet emissions are 100% offset via Greenfleet annually (392 tCO ₂ -e). The Sustainable Procurement Roadmap (2024) further embeds carbon considerations into supplier engagement. Source: Annual Report 2024, pp. 70–71.
University of Sydney	0 / 2	No evidence of any internal carbon fund, shadow price, green revolving fund, or carbon levy in any document. The \$6m sustainability program expenditure in 2024 is centrally allocated, not an ICP mechanism. Source: Climate-related Financial Disclosure 2024, p. 11.
University of Queensland	1 / 2	Two mechanisms identified: (1) a framework for offsetting airline travel emissions is committed to in the strategy (implementation stage unconfirmed); (2) the UQ SRI Green

		Fund is a \$3m internally established fund applying ESG and carbon principles to investment decisions. Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, pp. 17, 31.
University of Western Australia	1/2	The Carbon Neutral Events Program supports staff and students to reduce and offset emissions from campus events, applying a financial carbon consequence at the event/activity level. This is less institutionally embedded than Monash's Flight Emissions Offset Program but constitutes a genuine carbon finance mechanism. Source: Sustainable Campus Operations page.
Adelaide University	0/2	No evidence of any carbon fund, offset levy, shadow price, or ICP-adjacent financial mechanism. Not applicable at this stage of institutional development.
Monash University	2/2	The Flight Emissions Offset Program, launched in 2024, charges carbon offset costs into grant applications, integrates a financial carbon cost into individual travel decision-making, and is underpinned by an Integrity Principles for Carbon Offsetting Framework. This is the most developed active financial carbon mechanism identified in the Go8 dataset. Source: ESG Report 2024, p. 39; Annual Report 2024, p. 102.
UNSW Sydney	1/2	UNSW's faculty/division carbon dashboards create the informational infrastructure for a future fee or fund mechanism, explicitly designed to drive behavioural change at the faculty level. No green revolving fund, shadow price, or carbon levy was identified. Score of 1 reflects meaningful proximity to ICP without a financial instrument in place. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 10.

G5 • AASHE STARS rating

Scoring guide: 0=Not rated/Bronze | 1=Silver | 2=Gold | 3=Platinum | Max score: 3 | Weight: ×1

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
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Australian National University	0 / 3	ANU does not hold an AASHE STARS rating and does not appear in the AASHE rated institutions database. It reports under NGER, the APS Net Zero framework, TEFMA, and the Commonwealth Climate Disclosure pilot. Source: AASHE STARS rated institutions database (verified).
University of Melbourne	0 / 3	No AASHE STARS rating. UniMelb does not appear in the AASHE rated institutions database. The Sustainability Plan references STARS terminology but does not indicate formal participation. Source: AASHE STARS database (verified).
University of Sydney	1 / 3	USyd achieved a Silver STARS rating in 2021 but the planned 2024 re-submission was cancelled due to resource constraints, making the Gold target by 2025 unachievable. The 2021 rating is now outside the three-year validity window. Score of 1 applied conservatively. Source: Sustainability Strategy Annual Report 2024, p. 71; reports.aashe.org.
University of Queensland	0 / 3	UQ's STARS rating expired in February 2024 and ongoing participation is explicitly under review. Its last recorded STARS score of 61.37 (consistent with a Gold/Platinum-level performance) has not been renewed. Score of 0 applied given lapsed status. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 21 (footnote 6).
University of Western Australia	1 / 3	UWA holds a current AASHE STARS Silver rating, submitted December 2025 under STARS Version 2.2 — the most recently submitted and still valid rating in the Go8 dataset. Source: STARS Rated Institutions document; Governance and Reporting page.
Adelaide University	0 / 3	No AASHE STARS rating. Adelaide University is a new institution with no STARS registration. Neither foundation university holds a current transferable STARS rating. Source: AASHE STARS database (verified).
Monash University	0 / 3	No AASHE STARS rating. Monash does not appear in the AASHE rated institutions database. Source: reports.aashe.org (verified).
UNSW Sydney	0 / 3	No AASHE STARS rating. UNSW does not appear in the AASHE rated institutions database. Source: reports.aashe.org (verified).

Dimension 3 — Operational Autonomy

O1 • Budget decentralisation model

Scoring guide: 0=Fully centralised | 1=Partial devolution | 2=RCM/IBB model | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×2

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	1/2	Council approves the annual budget centrally; Finance Committee oversees all college and subsidiary budgets. The 'Renew ANU' restructuring program signals significant central financial control being reasserted. No RCM model is evident.
University of Melbourne	1/2	Budget preparation and performance monitoring sit with University Executive, with Finance Committee overseeing financial governance centrally. Some devolution of divisional planning responsibility is evident, but no formal RCM or IBB model exists. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 54.
University of Sydney	1/2	Senate oversees financial governance centrally, with no mention of RCM or IBB. Faculties and schools operate within centrally approved allocations. Some operational devolution is implied by the faculty/school structure, but no formal decentralised budget model was identified.
University of Queensland	1/2	Senate approved UQ's budget for 2025 as a single institutional act; the Senate Finance Committee oversees financial governance centrally. No RCM, IBB, or faculty-level budget autonomy was found. Operational devolution is implied by the faculty/school structure but not formally confirmed.
University of Western Australia	1/2	No evidence of RCM or IBB. The Office of Sustainability sits within the CFO portfolio with central governance. The Strategic Resources Committee oversees financial matters centrally through the Senate. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 18.
Adelaide University	0/2	The 2024 budget is entirely transitional (\$146.5m in transition grant revenue), governed by a highly centralised structure by design. The Finance Committee (December 2024) oversees all financial decisions centrally. Source: Annual Report 2024, pp. 42–44.

Monash University	1 / 2	Monash has a five-year strategic budget approved by Council and a one-year operational budget monitored by the Resources and Finance Committee. 'Reduced financial allocations of capital and faculty spending' in 2024 confirms faculties operate within centrally allocated budgets. Risk management is described as 'centralising coordination while devolving responsibility.' No RCM or IBB model.
UNSW Sydney	1 / 2	UNSW is governed by a Council with a Finance and Strategy Committee overseeing financial performance centrally. A new Delegations Policy approved in 2024 implies structured but fundamentally centralised authority, with Faculty Executive Directors operating within centrally defined limits. No RCM or IBB model evident.

O2 • Departments billed for utilities

Scoring guide: 0=No (central billing) | 1=Some units | 2=Systematic billing | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×2

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	0 / 2	Central utility invoicing model is explicit. Energy data flows to a central resource data software system rather than to departments. Source: Carbon Accounting Methodology 2024, Appendix E, p. 46.
University of Melbourne	0 / 2	No evidence of departmental utility billing. Energy tracking is at building and campus level through the Smart Campus Energy program, used as a performance monitoring tool rather than an internal billing mechanism.
University of Sydney	0 / 2	No evidence of departmental utility billing. The AUMS rollout improves monitoring visibility but does not create financial accountability at unit level. Source: Sustainability Strategy Annual Report 2024, p. 33.
University of Queensland	0 / 2	No evidence of departmental utility billing. Sub-metering supports energy management and auditing, with a focus on institution-wide consumption targets rather than departmental cost accountability.

University of Western Australia	0 / 2	No evidence of departmental utility billing. Energy data flows centrally through the CFO/Operations portfolio. The Dashboard is a public reporting tool. Source: Governance and Reporting page.
Adelaide University	0 / 2	No operational campuses and no utility billing. Not applicable in 2024.
Monash University	0 / 2	Energy data is extracted from Buildings & Property invoices at estate management level, not departmental billing. No evidence of departments being charged for their utility consumption. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 104.
UNSW Sydney	0 / 2	Energy data is aggregated at campus level. The LEAF program tracks energy at lab level for efficiency purposes but is not a financial billing mechanism. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 26.

03 • Faculty procurement autonomy

Scoring guide: 0=Centralised | 1=Partial autonomy | 2=Decentralised | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×1.5

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	1 / 2	A revision of procurement delegations in 2024 to 'ensure clarity of controls' implies a structured but partially devolved delegation framework, with units holding spending authority up to defined thresholds. ANU participates in the Australian Universities Procurement Network. Procurement policy sits centrally, but some unit-level discretion is evident.
University of Melbourne	1 / 2	Procurement is framed centrally — the University tracks its entire procurement spend for Scope 3 emissions and embeds sustainable practices in procurement — but research grants and individual project budgets imply some unit-level spending discretion. Source: Annual Report 2024.

University of Sydney	1 / 2	Procurement is explicitly centrally governed, with a university-wide modern slavery due diligence framework and central procurement lifecycle management. No faculty-level procurement discretion is mentioned beyond implied research spending autonomy.
University of Queensland	0 / 2	Procurement is centrally governed. The strategy confirms UQ's procurement framework requires sustainability to be considered in all procurement processes — top-down, not devolved. Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, p. 23.
University of Western Australia	0 / 2	Procurement is centrally governed through the CSR Policy and DVC (Operations) portfolio. Sustainable procurement principles are embedded top-down with no evidence of faculty-level autonomy. Source: Governance and Reporting page.
Adelaide University	0 / 2	The Procurement Policy (effective 1 January 2026) is centrally governed through the DVC Corporate. No evidence of faculty-level procurement autonomy. Source: Procurement Policy.
Monash University	0 / 2	The university-wide Responsible Procurement Framework (2024) is centrally governed. A 2024 initiative to consolidate paper purchases made by staff suggests Monash is actively reducing faculty procurement autonomy, leaning toward a score of 0.
UNSW Sydney	1 / 2	The new Sustainable Procurement Framework is centrally governed, but work-specific training for Faculty Executive Directors to identify and remediate procurement risks implies faculty-level decision-making authority within the central framework. The 2024 Delegations Policy confirms a structured, partially devolved authority structure. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 23.

O4 • Active carbon-conscious travel policy

Scoring guide: 0=No policy | 1=Policy not enforced | 2=Active with tracking | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×1

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
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Australian National University	2 / 2	ANU has a comprehensive, actively tracked travel emissions reduction program targeting a 50% reduction from 2019 levels by 2025. Tools include a Travel Emissions Tracker, a Carbon Smart Travel Guide, a travel survey, and recognition via the Australasian Green Gown Awards. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, pp. 17–18.
University of Melbourne	2 / 2	UniMelb has the most advanced travel emissions governance in the Go8 dataset. Air travel emissions are 100% offset (22,092 tCO ₂ -e in 2024). The Thrust Carbon ISO 14083-assured tool makes flight emissions visible to travel bookers at point of booking. Fleet emissions are 100% offset via Greenfleet. A commuting survey tracks staff travel patterns biennially. Source: Climate Leadership page; Annual Report 2024, pp. 70–71.
University of Sydney	1 / 2	USyd has a target to reduce kilometres flown on University business by 20% by 2025 and a Sustainable Transport Action and Mobility Plan (STAMP), but progress is limited and the travel target is not among the 2025 priority targets. No dedicated travel emissions tracker equivalent to ANU's was identified. Source: Sustainability Strategy Annual Report 2024, pp. 75–78.
University of Queensland	2 / 2	Active tracked targets are in place for transport emissions including modal shift (20% increase in active transport), fleet electrification (25% zero-emissions fleet), and an airline travel offset framework under development. Travel emissions are named as a key Scope 3 category. Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, pp. 16–17.
University of Western Australia	1 / 2	The Carbon Neutral Events Program implicitly addresses some travel-related emissions. The UWA 2030 strategy encourages sustainable transportation but no dedicated travel emissions reduction target, travel survey, or per-trip tracking tool was found. Source: UWA 2030 Full Report, p. 25.
Adelaide University	0 / 2	No operational travel program, travel emissions data, or carbon-conscious travel policy exists for Adelaide University in 2024.
Monash University	2 / 2	The Flight Emissions Offset Program (launched 2024) is the most active, structured travel carbon governance mechanism in the Go8 dataset. It embeds offset costs into grant applications, provides a Carbon Smart travel guide, and is backed by an Integrity Principles

		framework. Business travel (Cat. 6 = 13,017 tCO ₂ -e) is tracked annually. Source: ESG Report 2024, p. 39; Annual Report 2024, p. 102.
UNSW Sydney	2 / 2	Business travel is measured (Cat. 6 = 26,758 tCO ₂ -e in 2024), tracked year-on-year against the SBTi target, and the carbon dashboards include travel emissions by faculty, enabling staff to monitor and reduce their own travel footprint. Emissions from business travel reduced by 10,182 tCO ₂ -e in 2024 due to lower emissions intensity of air travel bookings. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, pp. 10–11.

Dimension 4 — Policy & Regulatory Context

P1 • NGER/Safeguard Mechanism exposure

Scoring guide: 0=Below thresholds | 1=Approaching | 2=Subject to NGER | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×1.5

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	2 / 2	ANU is a mandatory NGER reporter as a Corporate Commonwealth entity, confirmed in the Environmental Sustainability Report and Carbon Accounting Methodology. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 42.
University of Melbourne	2 / 2	Confirmed via CER NGER database (2023–24): Scope 1 = 14,901 tCO ₂ -e; Scope 2 = 92,066 tCO ₂ -e. NGER reporting is embedded in the University's reporting boundary documentation. Source: NGER CER register screenshot.
University of Sydney	2 / 2	USyd is a mandatory NGER reporter, confirmed in multiple documents including the Annual Report energy table, which explicitly references figures from NGER submissions. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 56.

University of Queensland	2 / 2	Confirmed via the NGER CER public register: UQ (ABN 63 942 912 684) is a mandatory NGER reporter. Scope 1 = 2,319 tCO ₂ -e; Scope 2 = 103,886 tCO ₂ -e for 2023–24. Source: CER NGER register screenshot.
University of Western Australia	2 / 2	UWA is a mandatory NGER reporter, confirmed through its Annual Report compliance disclosures and the fact that the Dashboard emissions data is sourced from NGER-aligned reporting. Source: Annual Report 2024, pp. 17–18.
Adelaide University	1 / 2	Adelaide University is not yet a NGER reporter as it has no operational energy consumption. The Sustainability Policy references the NGER Act 2007 as related legislation, confirming the obligation is anticipated and built into the governance framework. Score of 1 reflects anticipated but not yet operative NGER obligation. Source: Sustainability Policy, Legislation section.
Monash University	2 / 2	NGER reporting is mandatory and explicitly stated, with voluntary limited assurance from a registered NGER auditor engaged annually. Source: ESG Report 2024, p. 39; Annual Report 2024, p. 103.
UNSW Sydney	2 / 2	UNSW explicitly reports under NGER and aligns its GHG methodology with the NGER Scheme's Measurement Determination. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 10.

P2 • AASB S2/TCFD/TEFMA voluntary adoption

Scoring guide: 0=Not applicable/none | 1=Voluntary | 2=Formally committed | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×1

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	1 / 2	ANU voluntarily participated in the Commonwealth Climate Disclosure (CCD) pilot in 2024 and published its first climate-related disclosures inside the statutory Annual Report. Full mandatory disclosure is required from 2025. Also voluntarily reports to TEFMA. Score of 1; likely to become 2 in next year's coding. Source: Annual Report 2024, pp. 141–146.
University of Melbourne	1 / 2	UniMelb has a formal Climate Active carbon neutral certification program, publishes an annual Sustainability Report with third-party offset procurement disclosure, and uses ISO

		14083 for flight emissions. Investment financed emissions are disclosed by asset class, consistent with TCFD-style reporting. Score of 1 — substantive voluntary disclosure without formal AASB S2 or TCFD framework adoption. Source: Data Tables, Responsible investments section.
University of Sydney	2/2	USyd is a Phase 1 reporting entity under NSW Treasury's mandatory AASB S2-aligned climate disclosure requirements. A full voluntary Climate-related Financial Disclosure was proactively published one year ahead of mandatory compliance, with independent limited assurance from BDO. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 55; Climate-related Financial Disclosure 2024, pp. 3, 21.
University of Queensland	0/2	No evidence of AASB S2, TCFD, or formal climate risk disclosure in any document. UQ is a Queensland statutory body not subject to NSW Treasury requirements. No voluntary climate-related financial disclosure was found. Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, p. 19.
University of Western Australia	1/2	UWA participated in the ACTS Climate Scenario Working Group, collaborating with 12 other Australian universities to develop sector-specific climate scenarios for risk assessment. No formal AASB S2/TCFD/Treasury disclosure was published in 2024. Source: Sustainable Campus Operations page.
Adelaide University	1/2	The Sustainability Policy commits to managing climate and nature-related enterprise risks — language that mirrors TCFD/AASB S2 frameworks directly. As a South Australian statutory body, Adelaide University will be subject to emerging mandatory climate disclosure requirements. Score of 1 — climate risk governance is embedded in founding policy but no formal disclosure has been produced. Source: Sustainability Policy, Principle 3.6.
Monash University	1/2	The 2023 ESG Report included Monash's first climate risk disclosure section. In 2024, this section was not repeated because the next ESG Statement is pending (expected late 2025). Score of 1 — prior-year disclosure exists but no formal AASB S2/TCFD disclosure was produced in 2024. Source: ESG Report 2024, p. 19.
UNSW Sydney	1/2	UNSW explicitly aligns its GHG methodology with proposed AASB requirements and IFRS S2, and undertook a climate risk and opportunity assessment in 2024. Formal disclosures are

		planned from 2025 Annual Reports onwards under NSW Treasury mandatory requirements. Score of 1 — aligned methodology and preparatory work, without yet producing a formal disclosure. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, pp. 10–11.
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P3 • Carbon risk hedge in strategy documents

Scoring guide: 0=None | 1=General risk language | 2=Explicit carbon hedging | Max score: 2 |

Weight: ×1

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	2 / 2	ANU introduced a formal climate risk management pillar in 2024 with explicit transition risk language that aligns with the hedging rationale. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, pp. 33–34.
University of Melbourne	2 / 2	Carbon risk is embedded across multiple instruments: the ICP feasibility study commitment, the Climate Active certification program, the Sustainable Investment Framework which integrates climate change risk into investment decision-making, and the climate positive by 2030 target. Source: Sustainability Plan 2030, pp. 55–56.
University of Sydney	2 / 2	Transition risks — including carbon pricing and regulatory change — are explicitly named in scenario analyses and the Climate-related Financial Disclosure, with quantified scenario analysis under SSP pathways. Source: Climate-related Financial Disclosure 2024, pp. 8, 11.
University of Queensland	1 / 2	Climate change is embedded throughout the Sustainability Strategy and the \$125m Warwick Solar Farm investment reflects long-term climate risk hedging behaviour. However, no explicit transition risk, carbon pricing risk, or regulatory carbon risk language appears in the provided documents. Source: Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025, pp. 19, 31.
University of Western Australia	2 / 2	Climate risk is explicitly named as a governance priority. UWA is described as assessing material climate risks and identifying opportunities to support the net-zero transition. The

		ACTS scenario work and the 2026 Emissions Reduction Plan reflect transition risk hedging behaviour. Source: Sustainable Campus Operations page.
Adelaide University	1 / 2	The Sustainability Policy defines physical and transitional climate risks explicitly and commits to embedding them in risk management. The Endowment Policy excludes companies deriving 10% or more of revenue from fossil fuel reserves. Together these constitute nascent but genuine carbon risk hedging behaviour. Source: Sustainability Policy, Definitions section; Endowment Policy, Principle 3.9.
Monash University	2 / 2	Transition and physical climate risks are explicitly embedded in Monash's ESG governance framework and the 2024 Annual Report expanded to incorporate a climate risk disclosure section. The Flight Emissions Offset Program is partly framed as a reputational and transition risk-hedging instrument. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 101.
UNSW Sydney	2 / 2	Climate risk and opportunity assessments were completed in 2024, framed around transition and physical risks, with outputs feeding into the UNSW risk management framework and planned mandatory disclosures from 2025. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 11.

P4 • Peer/normative pressure (sustainability rankings)

Scoring guide: 0=Not engaged | 1=Participates | 2=High performer | Max score: 2 | Weight: ×1

University	Score	Evidence and Justification
Australian National University	1 / 2	ANU engages with ACTS, TEFMA, GAUC, and the Australasian Green Gown Awards (Highly Commended finalist, 2024) but does not hold a STARS rating, which is the primary sustainability ranking benchmark in the sector. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, p. 38.

University of Melbourne	2/2	UniMelb ranked 9th globally and 1st in Australia in the QS Sustainability Rankings — the strongest sustainability ranking position in the Go8 dataset at time of assessment. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 2.
University of Sydney	2/2	USyd ranked 2nd in Australia and 11th globally in the 2025 QS Sustainability Rankings — a sustained high-performer position, not mere participation. Source: Sustainability Strategy Annual Report 2024, p. 6; Annual Report 2024, p. 35.
University of Queensland	1/2	UQ has historically been among the strongest sustainability rankers in the Go8 (STARS score 61.37, targeting Platinum), but the STARS rating lapsed in February 2024 and ongoing participation is under review. Score of 1 reflects continued engagement without the formal rating that confers the strongest peer pressure signal. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 21.
University of Western Australia	2/2	UWA holds an active STARS Silver rating (submitted December 2025) — the only current valid rating in the Go8 dataset — and its Sustainable Campus Dashboard won the 2024 TEFMA AECOM Innovation Award. Source: STARS Rated Institutions document; Annual Report 2024, p. 42.
Adelaide University	1/2	Adelaide University participates in ACTS and is connected to SA Zero and international research networks through its Sustainability Partners page. No standalone sustainability ranking or STARS rating exists for the new institution. Source: Sustainability Partners page.
Monash University	1/2	Monash won the 2024 Green Gown Australasia Award for Sustainability Champion – Student and was a finalist for Sustainability Leadership. It participates in ACTS and TEFMA but does not hold a top-tier sustainability ranking position. Source: Annual Report 2024, p. 102.
UNSW Sydney	2/2	UNSW ranked equal 12th globally in the 2025 QS Sustainability Rankings, 7th globally in the 2024 THE Impact Rankings, and 2nd in the world for SDG 13 Climate Action for two consecutive years — the strongest sustainability ranking performance in the Go8 dataset. Source: Environmental Sustainability Report 2024, pp. 3, 7.

Appendix B

Go8 ICP Readiness Assessment — Document Bibliography and Evidence Sources

This appendix records all primary sources consulted in constructing the Appendix A scoring instrument. Section B.1 lists university-specific documents organised by institution and provides a mapping to the variables and dimensions they are informed. Section B.2 lists cross-institutional and third-party sources used across multiple universities.

Where a document was accessed via a public web page (dashboard, operations page, governance page) rather than a downloadable report, the source description reflects the web context. NGER Public Register screenshots were taken during the coding period and are identified by institution in the evidence record.

B.1 University-Specific Sources

Australian National University

Document Title	Document Type	Variables & Dimensions	Notes / Key Pages
Annual Report 2024	Institutional report	Financial governance, budget structures, procurement delegations, climate risk management, sustainability performance (EA1-EA5, G1-G5, O1-O4, P1-P4)	Cited throughout all four dimensions. Covers APS Net Zero compliance, CCD pilot disclosures (pp. 141-146), environmental performance tables.

Environmental Sustainability Report 2024	Sustainability report	Scope 1, 2, and 3 inventory; Scope 3 category methodology; net-zero target; governance structures; ACTS/TEFMA/GAUC engagement; Green Gown Awards; travel emissions programme	Primary source for EA1, EA2, EA3, G1, G2, G3, P1, P4. Key pages: p. 4 (VC foreword), p. 5 and p. 42 (Scope 3 categories), p. 11 (governance), p. 13 (net-zero target), pp. 17–18 (travel programme), pp. 33–34 (climate risk), p. 38 (ACTS/GAUC engagement), p. 42 (NGER confirmation).
Carbon Accounting Methodology 2024	Technical methodology document	GHG Protocol alignment; Scope 1 and 2 source breakdown; Scope 3 per-category data sources and quality ratings; sub-metering coverage; central utility invoicing model	Primary source for EA1, EA3, EA4, EA5, O2. Key pages: p. 5 (methodology overview), p. 15 (sub-metering), Appendix C (Scope 1/2 breakdown), Appendix E pp. 46–47 (Scope 3 per-category sources).
Environmental Sustainability Plan 2026–2030 (ESP 2026–2030)	Strategic plan	Carbon Smart Travel Program; supplier emissions reporting mandates; ICP-adjacent mechanisms	Cited for G4. Key pages: pp. 20, 33.
CER NGER Public Register	Regulatory database	Confirmed NGER reporting obligation as a Corporate Commonwealth entity	Used to verify P1. Accessed via the Clean Energy Regulator's public register.

University of Melbourne

Document Title	Document Type	Variables & Dimensions	Notes / Key Pages
Annual Report 2024	Institutional report	Scope 1 and 2 inventory; Scope 3 categories; travel offset data; financial governance; QS Sustainability Ranking	Cited across EA1, EA2, G1–G5, O1, P1. Key pages: p. 2 (QS ranking), p. 54 (budget governance), pp. 69–71 (GHG data tables).
Data Tables (GHG Emissions by Scope; GHG Emissions by Category 2024; Responsible Investments)	Supplementary data publication	Full itemised Scope 3 inventory (18 categories, 175,574 tCO ₂ -e); responsible investment disclosures	Primary source for EA2, EA3, P2. Published alongside the Annual Report 2024.
Sustainability Plan 2030	Strategic plan	ICP feasibility study commitment; net-zero and climate positive targets; carbon risk integration; governance structure; COO accountability	Primary source for G1, G2, G3, G4, P2, P3. Key pages: pp. 18–20 (targets), p. 20 (ICP commitment), pp. 55–59 (governance and risk).
Climate Leadership Page (University of Melbourne website)	Web page	Smart Campus Energy Upgrades Program; hybrid Scope 3 methodology; Thrust	Cited for EA3, EA5, G4, O4.

		Carbon ISO 14083 tool; fleet offset via Greenfleet	
CER NGER Public Register	Regulatory database	Confirmed NGER reporting: Scope 1 = 14,901 tCO ₂ -e; Scope 2 = 92,066 tCO ₂ -e (2023–24)	Used to cross-verify EA1 and P1.

University of Sydney

Document Title	Document Type	Variables & Dimensions	Notes / Key Pages
Annual Report 2024	Institutional report	Scope 1/2 inventory; NGER confirmation; financial governance; Senate oversight; QS Sustainability Ranking	Cited for EA1, G2, O1, P1, P4. Key pages: p. 35 (QS ranking), p. 55 (AASB S2 disclosure), p. 56 (NGER confirmation, Scope 1 figure).
Climate-related Financial Disclosure 2024	Climate financial disclosure	All 15 GHG Protocol Scope 3 categories; hybrid EEIO + process-based methodology via GLORIA database; Scope 3 limited assurance by BDO; net-zero target boundaries; scenario analysis; transition risk; ICP/governance language	Primary source for EA2, EA3, G1, G3, P2, P3. Key pages: p. 2 (VC/Chancellor foreword), p. 5 (governance structure), pp. 8, 11 (scenario analysis), pp. 17, 23 (target boundaries), pp. 21–23 (Scope 3 methodology). Published voluntarily ahead of mandatory NSW Treasury requirement.

Sustainability Strategy Annual Report 2024	Sustainability report	AUMS sub-metering rollout; carbon-conscious travel target; STARS Silver (2021) re-submission cancellation; governance body meeting frequency; QS ranking	Cited for EA5, G2, G5, O4, P4. Key pages: p. 6 (QS ranking), p. 33 (AUMS metering), p. 34 (Scope 1/2), p. 71 (STARS), pp. 75–78 (travel policy).
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University of Queensland

Document Title	Document Type	Variables & Dimensions	Notes / Key Pages
Annual Report 2024	Institutional report	Scope 1 and 2 inventory; Sustainability Strategy Committee establishment; STARS rating lapse; sub-metering; financial governance	Cited for EA1, G1, G2, G5, O1, O2, P4. Key pages: p. 21 (STARS lapse, footnote 6), p. 26 (KPIs), p. 27 (governance structure).
Sustainability Strategy 2021–2025	Strategic plan	Scope 3 airline travel commitment; 'beyond carbon neutral' vision; NGER reporting; Warwick Solar Farm; SRI Green Fund; procurement sustainability; UQ Scope 3 categories; travel targets	Primary source for EA2, EA3, EA5, G1, G3, G4, O3, O4, P1, P3. Key pages: p. 5 (VC foreword), pp. 15–17 (energy/emissions), p. 19 (Scope 3/targets), p. 23 (procurement), pp. 27–28 (governance), p. 31 (SRI fund).

CER NGER Public Register	Regulatory database	Confirmed NGER reporting: Scope 1 = 2,319 tCO ₂ -e; Scope 2 = 103,886 tCO ₂ -e (2023–24), ABN 63 942 912 684	Used to verify EA1 and P1.
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University of Western Australia

Document Title	Document Type	Variables & Dimensions	Notes / Key Pages
Annual Report 2024	Institutional report	NGER reporting confirmation; CFO oversight of Office of Sustainability; Strategic Resources Committee; STARS Silver reference; TEFMA Award; campus Scope 3 summary	Cited for G2, G5, O1, O3, P1, P4. Key pages: pp. 17–18 (NGER/governance), pp. 42–43 (sustainability performance, TEFMA Award).
Sustainable Campus Dashboard (UWA website)	Web-based reporting tool	Scope 1 and 2 inventory with historic data 2022–2025; Scope 3 aggregate figure (34.3K tCO ₂ -e); renewable electricity transition; sub-metering extent	Cited for EA1, EA2, EA3, EA5, G1. TEFMA AECOM Innovation Award recipient 2024.

Sustainable Campus Operations Page (UWA website)	Web page	Carbon Neutral Events Program; ACTS Climate Scenario Working Group participation; Emissions Reduction Plan commitment; procurement governance	Cited for G4, O3, O4, P2, P3.
Governance and Reporting Page (UWA website)	Web page	Office of Sustainability organisational placement; CFO as Executive Sponsor; STARS Silver confirmation; annual reporting schedule	Cited for G2, G5, O1, O2, P4.
UWA 2030 Full Report	Strategic plan	Campus sustainability as strategic pillar; VC-level climate commitment; sustainable transportation encouragement	Cited for G3, O4. Key page: p. 25.
AASHE STARS Rated Institutions Document	Database / certification record	UWA STARS Silver rating confirmed, submitted December 2025 under STARS Version 2.2	Cited for G5, P4.

Adelaide University

Document Title	Document Type	Variables & Dimensions	Notes / Key Pages
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Annual Report 2024	Institutional report	No operational emissions in 2024; NGER absence; transitional budget (\$146.5m grant revenue); Finance Committee establishment (December 2024); Audit and Risk Committee (August 2024); co-VCs foreword	Cited for EA1, G2, G3, O1. Key pages: p. 5 (foreword), pp. 42–44 (financial structure).
Sustainability Policy (effective 11 March 2026)	Governance policy	Net-zero by 2050 with full Scope 3 value chain; Council-level accountability; DVC Corporate as policy owner; physical and transitional climate risk definitions; NGER Act 2007 cited as related legislation; climate risk embedding	Primary source for EA1, G1, G2, G3, P1, P2, P3. Key principles: 3.5 (net zero), 3.6 (climate risk), 3.9 (governance).
Endowment Policy	Governance policy	Fossil fuel exclusion: companies deriving $\geq 10\%$ of revenue from fossil fuel reserves excluded from endowment investments	Cited for P3 (Principle 3.9).

Procurement Policy (effective 1 January 2026)	Governance policy	Centrally governed; DVC Corporate oversight; no faculty-level autonomy	Cited for O3.
Sustainability Partners Page (Adelaide University website)	Web page	ACTS membership; SA Zero connection; international research network links	Cited for P4.
CER NGER Public Register	Regulatory database	Confirmed absence of NGER entry for Adelaide University's ABN; foundation universities hold separate NGER registrations	Used to verify EA1 and P1.

Monash University

Document Title	Document Type	Variables & Dimensions	Notes / Key Pages
Annual Report 2024	Institutional report	Energy by campus facility (11 sites); MBA Scope 3 analytics project; faculty budget allocations; Resources and Finance Committee; ESG & Estates Committee; carbon management section;	Cited across EA1, EA2, EA4, EA5, G1–G5, O1–O4, P1, P3, P4. Key pages: p. 83 (analytics project), pp. 101–103 (carbon management), pp. 104–105 (energy by site).

		Flight Emissions Offset Program; NGER assurance; climate risk disclosure section; Green Gown Awards	
ESG Report 2024	ESG report	Full Scope 3 inventory (9 categories); hybrid LCA/spend methodology; NGER voluntary assurance; ESG & Estates Committee structure; Flight Emissions Offset Program; VC foreword; Integrity Principles for Carbon Offsetting; investment emissions (Cat. 15)	Primary source for EA2, EA3, G1, G2, G3, G4, O4, P1. Key pages: p. 5 (VC foreword), pp. 16–17 (governance), p. 19 (prior climate disclosure), p. 39 (Scope 3/NGER), p. 41 (Appendix 3 — Scope 3 categories).

UNSW Sydney

Document Title	Document Type	Variables & Dimensions	Notes / Key Pages
Annual Report 2024	Institutional report	Council sustainability oversight; Sustainable Procurement Framework endorsement; Safety and Risk Committee biannual	Cited for G2, G3, O1, O3. Key pages: p. 18 (Council oversight).

		climate risk review; climate risk assessments 2024; Delegations Policy	
Environmental Sustainability Report 2024	Sustainability report	Full Scope 1/2 inventory with BSI Group ANZ third-party assurance; Scope 3 categories (8); hybrid LCA/activity methodology; IFRS S2/AASB alignment; Power BI faculty/division carbon dashboards; business travel reduction; LEAF lab energy programme; QS and THE rankings; Sustainable Procurement Framework; SBTi target milestones	Primary source for EA1, EA2, EA3, EA4, EA5, G1–G5, O2–O4, P1–P4. Key pages: pp. 3–4 (VC foreword), p. 7 (THE ranking), pp. 10–11 (methodology, targets, Scope 3), p. 23 (procurement), p. 26 (campus energy/LEAF).

B.2 Cross-Institutional and Third-Party Sources

The following sources were used across multiple universities or underpin the scoring framework itself.

Source	Scope of Use	Notes
AASHE STARS Rated Institutions Database https://reports.aashe.org	Verified STARS rating status for all eight universities. Used to confirm presence or absence of a current valid rating for ANU, UniMelb,	Accessed during coding. Results recorded as AASHE STARS database (verified) in evidence justifications.

	USyd (2021 Silver, lapsed), UQ (lapsed February 2024), UWA (Silver, December 2025), Adelaide, Monash, UNSW.	
CER NGER Public Register https://www.cleanenergyregulator.gov.au/NGER	Confirmed NGER reporting status and 2023–24 Scope 1 and 2 figures for ANU, UniMelb, UQ, UWA, Monash, UNSW. Confirmed absence of entry for Adelaide University. Used to triangulate EA1 and P1 scores across all universities.	Screenshots cited throughout the evidence record.
Gorbach, I., Hauer, G., & Wyatt, A. (2022). Internal Carbon Pricing in the Higher Education Sector: Design Considerations and Implementation Pathways. <i>Journal of Cleaner Production</i> , 340, 130813.	Foundational reference underpinning both hard barrier rules (Hard Barrier 1: Emissions Accounting < 40%; Hard Barrier 2: Operational Autonomy < 40%). Cited in Section A.1 of the scoring instrument.	Not a document produced by any Go8 institution. Cited as the theoretical basis for the ICP readiness framework itself.

B.3 Source Count Summary

Institution / Category	Number of Primary Sources
Australian National University	5
University of Melbourne	5
University of Sydney	3
University of Queensland	3
University of Western Australia	6
Adelaide University	6
Monash University	2
UNSW Sydney	2
Cross-institutional and third-party sources (Section B.2)	3
Total unique sources consulted	35

AI Declaration

I declare that AI tools (Claude.ai) were used in the preparation of this research in the following ways.

1. **Instrument design phase:** I developed the initial variable set and scoring criteria independently. I subsequently used Claude to review and stress-test the instrument against the theoretical framework, identifying potential gaps or inconsistencies. All final decisions about variable inclusion, weighting, and scoring criteria were made by me.
2. **Data analysis:** I conducted the primary document analysis for all eight universities independently, producing initial scores and coding decisions. I then used Claude to cross-check my readings against the source documents. All final scoring judgments, including decisions about conservative coding and threshold cases, were made by me.
3. **Writing assistance:** I used Claude for editing and grammar checking. All intellectual content, arguments, analytical interpretations, and conclusions in this thesis are my own.